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# Left Turn

*A Quarterly Journal of Critical Voices*



**America's Reckoning: The Search for  
Humanity in a Time of Genocide**

*Elaheh Farmand*

**The Erasure of Gaza**

*Faramarz Farbod*

**Your Enemies Destroyed One Palestine;  
My Wounds Populated Many Palestines**

*Vijay Prashad*

**Red Current, Pink Tide: El Maizal Commune**

*Chris Gilbert*

**'I Am You': A Poem From Gaza To Israel**

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### Notes From the Editor

The regime of capital continues to ravage the planet for the sake of profit and capital accumulation. Undoubtedly, this is the most consequential of the crises humanity faces today. The continued warming of the planet is one example of how the Earth’s ability to sustain life as we know it is at risk. Scientists report that 2023 was “virtually certain” to be the warmest in 125,000 years.

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*The rule of capital necessitates super-exploitation of labor on a global scale* that has created a system of global apartheid based on class relations, ownership of resources, and wealth accumulation. Data on global inequalities [shows](#) that the wealthiest 10% of the people in the world own 76% of global wealth. They receive more than 52% (on average \$334 per day) of the global income while the poorest 50% share only about 8% (on average \$10 per day) between them.

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*The rule of Capital is failing on its own advertised terms:* “This year’s report found that the majority of billionaires that accumulated wealth in the last year did so through inheritance as opposed to entrepreneurship,” Benjamin Cavalli, head of strategic clients at UBS Global Wealth Management, said in a statement. “This is a theme we expect to see more of over the next 20 years.”

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*US imperialism continues to ravage the lives of millions of people in the global south.* For example, the US persists in defying the will of nearly the entire world to maintain a criminal policy of economic strangulation of Cuba for its disobedience of the US diktats. On 2 November the UN General Assembly voted for the 31st time on lifting the criminal 60+-year unilateral US blockade of Cuba. The [vote](#) was 187 in favor, 2 opposed, and 1 abstention. The two opposed votes were cast by the USA and Israel, with Ukraine abstaining.

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Contributed work does not necessarily represent the views of the Alliance.

## 'Your Enemies Destroyed One Palestine; My Wounds Populated Many Palestines'

VIJAY PRASHAD



*Malak Mattar (Palestine), A Life Stolen Before It Had Begun, 2023.*

The indecency of the phrase 'humanitarian pause' is obvious. There is nothing humanitarian about a brief interlude between bouts of horrendous violence. There is no true 'pause', merely the calm before the storm continues. We are witnessing the bureaucratization of immorality, the use of old words with great meaning ('humanitarian') and their reduction to new, empty phrases that betray their original meanings. Before the debris from the first rounds of Israeli bombs could be cleared, the bombing resumed just as viciously as before.

The word 'humanitarian' has been severely bruised by the West. You might remember another phrase, 'humanitarian intervention', that was used as cover for the destruction of Libya in 2011 after the legitimacy of Western military intervention had been eviscerated by the illegal US invasion of Iraq in 2003. To rehabilitate this legitimacy, the West pushed the United Nations to hold a conference that resulted in a new doctrine, Responsibility to Protect (R2P), which, while purporting to 'ensure that the international community never again fails to halt the mass atrocity crimes of genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing and crimes against humanity', instead provided the West with a UN Security Council mandate (under Chapter VII of the UN Charter) for the use of force. The attack on Libya in 2011 took place under this doctrine. The guise of humanitarianism was used to destroy the Libyan state and throw the country into what appears to be a permanent civil war. There has never been even

a whiff of R2P when it comes to the Israeli bombardment of Gaza (not in 2008–09, not in 2014, and not now).

It does not seem to matter that more Palestinians have been displaced and killed by Israel since 7 October than were displaced and killed in the Nakba ('Catastrophe') of 1948. If the word 'humanitarian' meant something in 1948, it certainly does not mean much now.

As the numbers of the dead and displaced increase, a sense of numbness grows. It began with a hundred dead, then a hundred more, and is rapidly escalating into the tens of thousands. In Iraq, approximately a million people were killed by the US onslaught, the sheer scale of death and the anonymity surrounding it forcing a sense of distance from the rest of the world. It is difficult to wrap one's head around these numbers unless there are stories attached to each of the dead and displaced.

Part of the problem here is that the international division of humanity makes for unjust accounting of human life: were the Palestinians killed in Gaza treated with as much dignity as the Israelis killed on 7 October? Are their lives, and deaths, assigned equal worth? The uneven response to these deaths, alongside the uncritical acceptance of this unevenness, suggests that this international division of humanity remains in place and is not only accepted, but also perpetuated, by Western leaders, who make allowances for the killing of more brown bodies than white ones, the latter seen as precious, the former seen as disposable.

During the 'humanitarian pause', a hostage transfer took place through which Hamas and the Palestinian factions released 110 Israelis while Israel [released](#) 240 Palestinian women and children. The stories of the Israeli casualties, many of them residents of settlements near the Gaza perimeter fence, and other hostages such as the Thai and Nepalese fieldworkers are now well-known. Less frequently discussed and much less understood are the stories of the Palestinian casualties. Equally disregarded is the fact that after 7 October, Israel launched a mass campaign to detain over 3,000 Palestinians, including nearly 200 children. There are more Palestinians in Israeli prisons [now](#) than before 7 October. During the first four days of the truce alone, Israel arrested almost as many Palestinians as it released through the hostage transfer.

It is of note that most (more than [two-thirds](#)) of the Palestinians released from Israeli prisons are never charged with any crime and have been held in '[administrative detention](#)' in the military's legal system, meaning that they are held without a time limit, 'without trial [and] without having committed an offence, on the grounds that he or she plans to break the law in the future', as defined by the human rights organization B'Tselem. Some of them have been lost in the maze of the Israeli incarceration system indefinitely, unable to exercise even the most basic right of habeas corpus, with no court appearance, no access to a lawyer, and no access to the evidence against them. Israel currently [holds](#) more than 7,000 Palestinian political prisoners, many of them associated with left-wing factions (such as the Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine and the Democratic Front for the Liberation of Palestine). More than 2,000 of these prisoners are being held in administrative detention.

Many of these Palestinian prisoners are children. Many of them spend years in the Israeli system, often under administrative detention, unable to make a case for their release. The Defense for Children International (Palestine) [reports](#) that 500–700



children are detained each year, and a chilling [report](#) from the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) in 2015 showed that Israel is in full violation of the [UN Convention on the Rights of the Child](#) (1990). Article 37 of the convention says that the 'arrest, detention, or imprisonment of a child shall be in conformity with the law and shall be used only as a measure of last resort and for the shortest appropriate period of time'. As multiple cases show, Israel uses arrests as a measure of first resort and holds children for long periods of time.



Abdel Rahman al-Muzayen (Palestine), *Untitled*, 2000.

Defense for Children International [studied](#) sworn affidavits from 766 child detainees from the occupied West Bank arrested between 1 January 2016 and 31 December 2022. The following data emerged from their analysis: 75% were subjected to physical violence.

- 80% were strip-searched.
- 97% were interrogated without a family member present.
- 66% were not properly informed of their rights.

- 55% were shown or made to sign a paper in Hebrew, a language most Palestinian children do not understand.
- 59% were arrested at night.
- 86% were not informed of the reason for their arrest.
- 58% were subjected to verbal abuse, humiliation, or intimidation during or after their arrest.
- 23% were detained in solitary confinement for interrogation purposes for a period of two or more days.

There are thousands of untold stories of the brutality inflicted upon Palestinian children. One of them, [Ahmad Manasra](#), was arrested on 12 October 2015 at the age of thirteen in occupied East Jerusalem on the charge that he stabbed two Israelis: Yosef Ben-Shalom, a twenty-year-old security guard, and Naor Shalev Ben-Ezra, a thirteen-year-old boy, who survived the attack. The Israeli courts initially found Ahmad guilty of the stabbing but then changed their opinion to say that his fifteen-year-old cousin Hassan Khalid Manasra, who was shot dead at the scene, had stabbed the two Israelis. There was no evidence of Ahmad's complicity, yet he was sentenced to nine-and-a-half years in prison.

Still in prison, Ahmad Manasra (now 21) has been held in solitary confinement for months on end. Khulood Badawi of Amnesty International [said](#) in late September that Ahmad 'was taken to the mental health unit at Ayalon prison after spending the better part of two years in solitary confinement. The Israeli Prison Service has requested an extension of Ahmad's isolation for another six months in brazen violation of international law. Prolonged solitary confinement lasting more than 15 days violates the absolute prohibition of torture and other cruel, inhuman, or degrading treatment'.

Ahmad's case took place during a wave of what were called 'knife attacks', when young Palestinians were accused of rushing at Israeli military posts with knives and were then shot dead. At that time, I investigated several of these attacks and found them to be based on little more than the word of Israeli soldiers. For instance, on 17 December 2015, Israeli soldiers at the Huwwara checkpoint shot fifteen-year-old Abdullah Hussein Ahmad Nasasra to death. Eyewitnesses told me that the boy had his hands in the air when he was fatally shot. One of them, Nasser, told me that there was no knife, and that he 'saw them kill the boy'. Kamal Badran Qabalan, an ambulance driver, was not allowed to retrieve the body. The Israelis wanted control over the body and the story they would tell about it.

Another [story](#) is that of twenty-three-year-old Anas al-Atrash in Hebron. Anas and his brother Ismail returned home from a week of work in Jericho, their car filled with fruits and vegetables. At a checkpoint, Anas got out of the car when instructed to do so and an Israeli soldier shot him dead. The next morning, Israeli media reported that Anas tried to kill the Israeli soldiers. The journalist Ben Ehrenreich, who reported the story with a fierce determination for the truth, sought out the family's version. Anas had no interest in politics, they told him. He was studying accounting and hoped to get married soon. The Israeli soldiers and intelligence officials kept asking Ismail if his brother had a knife. There was simply no knife. Anas had been killed

in cold blood. 'This is a savage country', an eyewitness [told](#) Ehrenreich. 'They have no shame'. He meant the Israeli soldiers.

The grammar of the Israeli occupation is to put pressure on Palestinians until an act of violence takes place—a knife attack, say, or even a fabricated knife attack—and then use that event as an excuse to deepen the displacement of Palestinians with more illegal settlements. The events that have followed 7 October maintain this logic. Israel has used people like Anas, Abdullah, and Ahmad, and the fabricated narratives surrounding their alleged crimes, as the *raison d'être* to increase the demolition of Palestinian homes and expand illegal Israeli settlements, accelerating the Permanent Nakba.

Ten years ago, I met with Professor Nadera Shalhoub-Kevorkian, who teaches at Hebrew University of Jerusalem. Shalhoub-Kevorkian studies how the occupation produces an everyday form of victimhood that stretches from the streets to Palestinians' most intimate of spaces. Her book [Security Theology, Surveillance, and the Politics of Fear](#) (2015) provides a glimpse into the industry of fear that is produced and reproduced in the everyday violence inflicted upon Palestinians by settlers and the military, including the difficulties that Palestinians face in giving birth and burying their dead. The depth of the violence and uncertainty, Shalhoub-Kevorkian writes, moves Palestinian women to speak of 'being choked, suffocated, or gagged' and has led many of their children to [lose](#) their will to live. There is widespread social trauma in Palestine or what Shalhoub-Kevorkian calls 'sociocide': the death of society.

More than fifty years of an occupation and war have created a strange dynamic. Both Ehrenreich and Shalhoub-Kevorkian's work offer windows into this madness. Shalhoub-Kevorkian, who lives in Jerusalem, told me that she is part of a group of women who walk Palestinian children to school each day, since it is too dangerous for them to confront the police and the settlers on their own, or even in the company of their Palestinian family and friends. 'Bikhawfuni!' ('They scare me!'), one girl, Marah (age 8), told her.

The children draw pictures at school. One of them drew a clown, a Palestinian clown. When Shalhoub-Kevorkian asked the child (age 9) what a Palestinian clown is, he explained, 'This is a Palestinian clown. Clowns in Palestine cry'.

The poet Faiz Ahmed Faiz, who moved to Beirut to edit the magazine *Lotus* in the aftermath of the 1977 military coup in Pakistan, wrote with horror about the plight and struggles of the Palestinians:

*Tere aaqa ne kiya ek Filistin barbaad  
Mere zakhmon ne kiye kitne Filistin aabaad.*

Your enemies destroyed one Palestine.  
My wounds populated many Palestines.

Faiz's poem 'A Lullaby for a Palestinian Child', written during the Israeli invasion of Lebanon in 1982, reflects the reality facing Palestinian children today:

Don't cry children.  
Your mother has just cried herself to sleep.

Don't cry children.  
Your father has just left this world of sorrow.

Don't cry children,  
Your brother is in an alien land.  
Your sister too has gone there.

Don't cry children.  
The dead sun has just been bathed and the moon is buried in  
the courtyard.

Don't cry children.  
For if you cry,  
Your mother, father, brother, and sister  
And the sun, and the moon  
Will make you cry ever more.

Maybe if you smile,  
They'll one day return, disguised  
to play with you.

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## Erasing Gaza

FARAMARZ FARBOD

In the words of the UN Chief Antonio Guterres, the US-Israel assault has created “a graveyard for children” in Gaza, a tiny sliver of land that is home to several generations of impoverished refugees, half of whom are children. Gazans arguably make up one of the most vulnerable populations globally. They live in the “largest open-air prison” or the “largest concentration camp” in the world. Since 2007, Gazans have been subjected to a cruel siege by Israel, with cooperation from Egypt, and support from the US, which has led to unbearable conditions of life. As early as 2012, the UN [warned](#) that Gaza would become “uninhabitable” by the year 2020 with 60% of its households already “either food insecure or vulnerable to food insecurity” in 2012 “even when taking into account the UN food distributions to almost 1.1 million people.” The UN said Gaza was “kept alive through external funding and the illegal tunnel economy.” Since the siege began, Israel has militarily assaulted Gaza at least six times killing thousands, injuring many thousands more, and destroying homes and critical infrastructure in what it cynically calls “mowing the lawn”.

As bad as the conditions had been pre-October 7, they are now unimaginably worse. [Between 7 October and 30 December](#), the US-Israeli assault killed 30,034 Palestinians (11,833 of whom are infants and children, 6,009 women, and 27,681 civilians) and injured 58,313. The dead include 104 journalists and 236 healthcare professionals. By now over 1.9 million Gazans have been displaced, out of a total population of 2.2 million.

Human Rights Watch has [accused](#) Israel of using the starvation of civilians as a weapon of war. The Israeli forces, it said, are “depriving the civilian population of objects indispensable to their survival.” Israel bombed “Gaza’s last operational wheat mill on November 15” ensuring that “locally produced flour will be unavailable in Gaza for the foreseeable future.” The “decimation of road networks,” the destruction of “Bakeries and grain mills... agriculture, water and sanitation facilities,” and the “sustained bombardment, coupled with fuel and water shortages, alongside the displacement of more than 1.6 million people to southern Gaza, has made farming nearly impossible.” The report states that “agricultural land, including orchards, greenhouses, and farmland in northern Gaza, has been razed,” and that “livestock in the north are facing starvation due to the shortage of fodder and water, and that crops are increasingly abandoned and damaged due to lack of fuel to pump irrigation water.” Another [report by 23 UN and non-governmental agencies](#) has found that the entire population of Gaza faces an imminent risk of famine if present genocidal policies continue, with 576,600 persons at catastrophic or starvation levels. “It is a situation where pretty much everybody in Gaza is hungry,” said the World Food Program economist.

At least 369,000 Gazans are [suffering](#) from infectious diseases under rapidly declining health conditions. “We are all sick,” the *New York Times* quoted Samah al-Farra “a 46-year-old mother of 10 struggling to care for her family in a camp hous-

ing displaced Palestinians in Rafah, in southern Gaza. ‘All of my kids have a high fever and a stomach virus.’” At the time of the gravest healthcare need, according to the World Health Organization, just 9 out of 36 health facilities in Gaza are operating, and only partially. At the same time, there are “no functional hospitals left in the north.”

The deliberate destruction of Gaza’s health system amounts to a slow and more painful death sentence for the tens of thousands of injured whose minimal urgent care needs cannot be met.

The US-Israel genocidal assault on Gaza reveals much about the US political system and the ‘rules-based international order’ as well. For example, a poll in mid-December [showed](#) that 68% of US Americans, three-quarters of Democrats, and half of Republicans support a ceasefire. Contrast those numbers with not only the refusal of the Biden administration to support a truce but the fact that as of 21 December only 62 members of Congress (11.6%) had joined a call for a ceasefire. The persistence of a wide split between the political elites and the public is a clear indication of political dysfunctionality in the US—despite ongoing protests including the largest pro-Palestine demonstration in US history on November 4. There remains a slight window of opportunity to influence policy as the 2024 elections approach and polls indicate that the Biden administration is losing public support on this issue. [Reportedly](#) “there was some concern in the administration about an unintended consequence of the pause: that it would allow journalists broader access to Gaza and the opportunity to further illuminate the devastation there and turn public opinion on Israel” and against the Biden administration. A growing public opposition may be all we have in constraining Washington from pursuing a wider regional war on behalf of Israel.

It is important to note that the US, as the chief enabler of Israel, can stop this genocide. Instead, it continues to give full military, diplomatic, ideological, technological, and economic support to Israel. For example, *The Times of Israel* [reports](#) that “244 US transport planes and 20 ships have delivered more than 10,000 tons of armaments and military equipment to Israel since the start of the war.”

Furthermore, investigations by several mainstream US news establishments like the *New York Times* and CNN [show](#) that in the first month of its assault on Gaza Israel used mostly US-manufactured 2000-pound bunker-buster bombs. These heavy munitions “can cause high casualty events and can have a lethal fragmentation radius—an area of exposure to injury or death around the target—of up to 365 meters (about 1,198 feet), or the equivalent of 58 soccer fields in area.” According to CNN’s analysis: “Satellite imagery from those early days of the war reveals more than 500 impact craters over 12 meters (40 feet) in diameter, consistent with those left behind by 2,000-pound bombs. Those are four times heavier than the largest bombs the United States dropped on ISIS in Mosul, Iraq, during the war against the extremist group there.” CNN quotes John Chappell, “advocacy and legal fellow at CIVIC, a DC-based group focused on minimizing civilian harm in conflict” stating that “the use of 2,000-pound bombs in an area as densely populated as Gaza means it will take decades for communities to recover.”



Crucially, the US also shields Israel from global initiatives at the UN Security Council (UNSC) that aim at halting its consistent and gross violations of international humanitarian laws and the UNSC resolutions, including those calling for an immediate permanent ceasefire.

The most recent example of the latter occurred on 22 December. The US [abstained](#) from voting on a UNSC resolution (13-0-2) that called for aid access and temporary pauses in Israel's bombing of Gaza. For 5 days, the US delayed the vote on an earlier draft, a tactic aimed at giving Israel more time, and vetoed an amendment calling for a complete ceasefire and the establishment of a robust UN inspection mechanism in Gaza. The hollowed-out and meaningless resolution that was passed is another triumph for the US obstructionism in support of Israeli genocide albeit in the form of an abstention; earlier the US twice vetoed resolutions calling for immediate ceasefire and the release of all hostages.

The last time the US blocked a UNSC resolution calling for a ceasefire and the release of all hostages was on 7 December. UN Secretary-General Antonio Guterres had [invoked Article 99](#) of the UN Charter (a rare article akin to a global "panic button" to trigger a UNSC vote) and urged the UNSC to act on the war in Gaza. The UN chief referred to the situation in Gaza as "apocalyptic" and stated that he believes Gaza's humanitarian system and civil order are at risk of "complete collapse." The US not only vetoed the resolution but on that same day [approved](#) the sale and immediate delivery of 14,000 tank shells to Israel without congressional approval, displaying its dedication to protecting Israeli terrorism.

Less mentioned in the news is the US vote on 19 December against a [resolution](#) adopted by the UN General Assembly affirming the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination. The vote count was 172-4-10. The other three countries that joined the US to reject the resolution were Israel, Micronesia, and Nauru. Affirming the right of the Palestinian people to self-determination is the very heart of a just resolution of 'the Question of Palestine'. US rejectionism ensures the continuation of Israel's colonization, ethnic cleansing, apartheid, occupation, siege, and genocide, as well as Palestinian resistance to oppression and rightlessness.

Of course, the dominant view in the US equates Palestinian resistance with terrorism motivated by hatred of Jews. Such a view can only persist in the absence of historical context. To ensure that absence, corporate media rarely feature Palestinian voices. Propaganda often works not by spin alone; omission is a crucial part of manipulating public opinion. Omitting context has allowed the US and Israel to weaponize the October 7 Hamas attack to mobilize public support for the genocide and ethnic cleansing they are committing in Gaza, ostensibly in response to October 7. This is reminiscent of how the US hijacked the 9/11 attacks to silence dissent and push through its ruinous and criminal post-9/11 wars. Public opposition eventually emerged in the longer term to those 9/11 wars of choice.

The ongoing genocide in Gaza is no different although the shift in public opinion in the US has been much swifter this time as compared to the post-9/11 period. As mentioned above, by now most people in the US favor a ceasefire. Additionally, polls [found](#) that "more people ages 18–29 sympathized with Palestinians than with Israelis in the current conflict... 28 percent expressed more sympathy with Palestinians vs. 20

percent for Israelis." There have been massive pro-Palestinian protests globally and huge ones in the US, including unprecedented ones by staff at the State Department and the White House. Israeli Jews on the other hand have taken a super hawkish position on the use of force in Gaza. Polls [found](#) that just 1.8% believed Israel was using too much firepower in Gaza. That is a remarkable figure indeed and a sign of the general moral decline of Israeli society.

We might therefore say that to contextualize is to act radically because the resulting understanding undermines the dehumanizing and racialized language used to justify atrocities against the Palestinians, such as calling them terrorists, human animals, and antisemitic Nazis.

What then is the missing context for understanding what has been taking place in Palestine? To answer, we can begin by asking "What are the Palestinians struggling against?" and "What are the Palestinians fighting for?"

The Palestinians struggle against a US-backed Zionist colonizing state of Israel itself allied with several reactionary Arab client states of the US. They fight not just against Israeli apartheid, ethnic cleansing, occupation, siege, theft of their lands, and colonization, but against US imperialism. Israel is a component of the US empire and serves its interests in this region by opposing radical Arab nationalism. The Palestinians fight for a free Palestine with equal rights for all its inhabitants, including Muslims, Christians, Jews, Druze, the non-religious, and others. Because they cannot free themselves unless they defeat the forces of imperialism and reaction arrayed against them in the region, their liberation necessarily entails the possibility of liberation for all the peoples in the region.

In the broadest sense, the struggle for a free Palestine is a struggle for the liberation of all the peoples of that region from imperialism and domination. The proper context to view this is therefore a confrontation between imperialist domination and the people's movements for liberation. A sub-context of this confrontation is that between the Palestinians and the Zionist colonizing state of Israel. The latter is bent on completing its ethnic cleansing of historical Palestine and uses every opportunity to advance its incomplete project of settler colonialism until it achieves its final goal of conquering what it calls Greater Israel which includes the Occupied Palestinian Territories. The goal of Zionism is to take as much land of historical Palestine with as few Palestinians as possible. The Zionist colonizing state has waged a war on the Palestinians since 1948, not October 7.

October 7 provided Israel with another opportunity to further its ethnic cleansing objectives in Gaza. On the night that [Israel killed](#) 250 Palestinians, mostly women and children, and injured another 500 just in the 24 hours over Christmas eve, Benjamin Netanyahu, the rightwing prime minister of Israel, [announced](#) "the three prerequisites for peace between Israel and its Palestinian neighbors in Gaza": "We must destroy Hamas, demilitarize Gaza, and deradicalize the whole of Palestinian society." These are impossible objectives. Hamas is a resistance group. Even if all its members are killed, its ideology remains as one form of resistance to Israeli genocide, colonization, and oppression. It's dialectical, stupid!—repression generates resistance. Plus, the ongoing genocide will surely further radicalize the Palestinians in Gaza and the West Bank too, making Hamas more popular, not less, regardless of whether Israel can declare victory in Gaza. Even putting the latter point aside, the

goal of deradicalizing the Palestinians essentially means turning Palestinians into Zionists. That is even more absurd than the goal of eradicating Hamas. No wonder the Israeli army Chief of Staff [said](#) on the same day that “achieving war’s goals ‘will take months.’” By the time Israel is done, there will be no structures left for any Gazans to come back to while many tens of thousands more will have died due to the spread of infectious diseases, hunger, despair, and hardships of disruptions and displacements, if not from US-made bombs.

The genocidal actions of Israel in Gaza are consistent with a leaked document produced by Israel’s intelligence ministry 6 days after the bombing of Gaza began, titled ‘Options for a policy regarding Gaza’s civilian population’ that [recommended](#) the ethnic cleansing of Gaza with its population expelled into “tent cities” in Egypt’s Sinai peninsula before constructing cities in a “resettled area” in the north of Sinai to house them. So far Egypt has refused to cooperate.

But the Egyptian intransigence may not have stopped Israel from its forced mass displacement plans. According to an [Israeli daily newspaper report](#) published in early December, Netanyahu plans in secret to “[thin out](#)” the population of Gaza. He has “instructed Ron Dermer, his minister of strategic planning and a close aide, to have a plan for the ‘day after’ in Gaza and, if necessary, one that ‘enables a mass escape [of Palestinians] to European and African countries’ by opening sea routes out of the strip.” The report said that “Netanyahu sees this as a strategic goal.”

Indeed, the UN expert [warned](#) on 22 December that Israel is working to expel the civilian population of Gaza. Paula Gaviria Betancur, Special Rapporteur on the human rights of internally displaced persons (IDPs), said “As evacuation orders and military operations continue to expand and civilians are subjected to relentless attacks on a daily basis, the only logical conclusion is that Israel’s military operation in Gaza aims to deport the majority of the civilian population en masse.”

It’s worth noting that Israeli Jews are overwhelmingly supportive of ethnically cleansing Gaza. A Direct Survey poll published on December 21 in Israel included the following question: “To what degree do you support encouraging the voluntary emigration of Gaza Strip residents?” The [response](#) was as follows: “68% support it strongly,” “15% are quite supportive,” “8% don’t really support it,” and “9% don’t support it at all.” That is, 83% favor what is euphemistically called “voluntary emigration” but is ethnic cleansing and a war crime.

The deafening din of Zionist propaganda in the US has drowned two essential truths about the Question of Palestine:

1. The Palestinians are not fighting Israel because they hate Jews. They are fighting against their dispossession, occupation, and erasure and for liberation from oppression, domination, colonization, and imperialism.
2. The source of the problem isn’t the Palestinian resistance, in whatever form, but the US imperialist domination of the region in alliance with the racist Zionist colonizing state of Israel and a coterie of reactionary Arab states.

The historical contextualization would undermine the dominant dehumanizing Zionist narrative and open pathways for crucial solidarity work towards a free, democratic, equal, and inclusive Palestine from the river to the sea.

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## ‘I Am You’: A Poem From Gaza To Israel

REFAAT ALAREER

...Look in the mirror: The horror, the horror!  
 The butt of your M-16 on my cheekbone  
 The yellow patch it left  
 The bullet-shaped scar expanding  
 Like a swastika,  
 Snaking across my face,  
 The heartache flowing  
 Out of my eyes dripping  
 Out of my nostrils piercing  
 My ears flooding  
 The place.  
 Like it did to you  
 70 years ago  
 Or so.

I am just you.  
 I am your past haunting  
 Your present and your future.  
 I strive like you did.  
 I fight like you did.  
 I resist like you resisted  
 And for a moment,  
 I’d take your tenacity  
 As a model,  
 Were you not holding  
 The barrel of the gun  
 Between my bleeding  
 Eyes.

One. Two.  
 The very same gun  
 The very same bullet  
 That had killed your Mom  
 And killed your Dad  
 Is being used,  
 Against me,  
 By you.



Mark this bullet and mark in your gun.  
If you sniff it, it has your and my blood.  
It has my present and your past.  
It has my present.  
It has your future.  
That's why we are twins,  
Same life track  
Same weapon  
Same suffering  
Same facial expressions drawn  
On the face of the killer,  
Same everything  
Except that in your case  
The victim has evolved, backward,  
Into a victimizer.  
I tell you.  
I am you.  
Except that I am not the you of now.

I do not hate you.  
I want to help you stop hating  
And killing me.  
I tell you: The noise of your machine gun  
Renders you deaf  
The smell of the powder  
Beats that of my blood.  
The sparks disfigure  
My facial expressions.  
Would you stop shooting?  
For a moment?  
Would you?

All you have to do  
Is close your eyes  
(Seeing these days  
Blinds our hearts.)  
Close your eyes, tightly  
So that you can see  
In your mind's eye.  
Then look into the mirror.  
One. Two.

I am you.  
I am your past.  
And killing me,  
You kill you.

If I Must Die  
If I must die,  
you must live  
to tell my story  
to sell my things  
to buy a piece of cloth  
and some strings,  
(make it white with a long tail)  
so that a child, somewhere in Gaza  
while looking heaven in the eye  
awaiting his dad who left in a blaze — and bid no one farewell  
not even to his flesh  
not even to himself — sees the kite, my kite you made, flying up above,  
and thinks for a moment an angel is there  
bringing back love.  
If I must die  
let it bring hope,  
let it be a story.

*Refaat Alareer was a prominent Palestinian writer, poet, professor, and activist from the Gaza Strip. On 6 December 2023, Israel targeted and killed him in an airstrike in northern Gaza, along with his brother, sister, and her three children.*

## “I refuse to take part in a revenge war”

*Tal Mitnick is the first Israeli conscientious objector to be imprisoned since Oct. 7. He explains why the current war has only reaffirmed his convictions.*

### OREN ZIV INTERVIEWS TAL MITNICK

Shortly before entering prison, Tal Mitnick spoke to +972 about his decision to refuse, the fear of entering prison in the current political climate, and the message he aims to convey to the public in Israel and in Gaza.

#### **How did your decision to refuse enlistment come about?**

Even before the first draft notice, I knew I was not interested in enlisting. I knew I wasn't willing to serve in this system that perpetuates apartheid in the West Bank and only contributes to the cycle of bloodshed. I understood from the very privileged position I find myself in, having a supportive family and environment, that I have an obligation to use it to reach other young people and to show that there is another way. When I talk to my friends—some of whom serve and some of whom received exemptions—about why I'm not going to the army, they understand that it comes from a humane perspective of consideration for the other. No one thinks I support Hamas or want [my friends] to experience harm. There are people who believe that military activity will bring security; I believe that my public refusal is what will influence and bring the most security.

#### **How did the protests against the judicial overhaul help you shape your worldview?**

Before the protests, I viewed political activism as something very distant, and I didn't think it was possible to make an impact as an individual. When the protests began and I saw they included members of Knesset going out to the streets, I realized that politics is closer to me than I thought, that it can reach every corner of the country, and that it is possible to have an influence. That's where I understood that my actions can affect the reality we see here, and I have an obligation to act for a better future.

#### **Were you debating whether to do it now, given the current atmosphere?**

Yes, there were doubts. I always knew that the army doesn't have a consistent policy regarding conscientious objectors, that the response can change in a moment—to release all objectors or to imprison them for a long time—and I was prepared for that. After October 7 and the [government's] attack on the peace movement, on Jewish-Arab partnership, and on Palestinian citizens expressing support and solidarity with the innocent in Gaza, even on demonstrations, it has become frightening. But now is precisely the time to show the other side, to show that we exist.

#### **Do you think there's anyone in the country willing to listen to such messages right now?**

We all know that we need another way, especially after October 7. We all know that it simply doesn't work, that Benjamin Netanyahu is not “Mr. Security.” Managing the conflict is a policy that hasn't worked and eventually collapsed. We can't continue with the current situation, and there are two options now: the right suggests transfer

and genocide of the Palestinians in Gaza; the other side says there are Palestinians here, living between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean Sea, and they are entitled to rights. Even people who voted for Bibi, and even those who supported the judicial reform, can connect to the idea that everyone deserves to live justly, that everyone deserves a roof over their heads, and support shared existence here.

#### **After October 7, many who were on the left claimed they “sobered up”. Did this affect you?**

There is no justification for harming innocent civilians. The criminal attack on October 7, in which innocents were killed, is illegitimate resistance to the oppression of the Palestinian people in my eyes. However, outlawing legitimate resistance such as protests, or declaring human rights organizations as terrorist organizations, leads people to dehumanize the other and to actions targeting civilians. October 7 did not change my perspective; it only reinforced it. I still believe it is impossible to live with the siege on Gaza and an occupation, and not feel [any consequences]. I believe that many people finally understand this. The idea of “out of sight, out of mind” doesn't work. Something needs to change, and the only way is to talk, to reach a political settlement. I'm not saying it will solve everything, but it will be another step toward justice and peace.

#### **What was your experience at the Conscience Committee?**

The pre-committee interviewer was aggressive. She questioned my nonviolence because I opposed the government's actions and the occupation. Essentially, due to my opinions, she told me that I am not a conscientious objector because these were political views. In the end, I went through the pre-committee, and appeared before the committee itself less than a week after the interview, while many people usually wait half a year. It was a hostile interview: me opposite four people.

They attacked my opinions. They asked me what I would have done on October 7, and how I would have handled the situation. They constantly interrupted me, and said they would phrase the question differently. I tried to continue answering, but they said I wasn't responding to them. I am not the leader of Israel; they can't place me in that position. They asked me how my refusal is different from the refusal of Brothers in Arms [a group of army veterans who declared their refusal to show up for reserve service in protest against the judicial coup]. I replied that I appreciate them and think it's important that there are people who have a red line for service—but I set my red line before that, and I hope their red line moves in the direction of my red line. Two days later, they told me I hadn't passed the committee. I wasn't surprised. I didn't receive any explanation, they just called and told me the result.

#### **How do you plan to pass the time in prison?**

I have a few long books, which I hope they will allow me to bring in: *Drinking the Sea at Gaza*, by Amira Hass, a history of the CIA, and a history of *The Mizrahi Struggle*, by Sami Shalom Chetrit. I spoke with conscientious objectors who were in prison before; it is definitely not a summer camp, but from what I understand, it is possible to cope with it. You just need to speak in the right way and not think that you are above anyone else.

*Oren Ziv is a photojournalist, reporter for Local Call, and a founding member of the Activestills photography collective. This interview originally appeared in [+972 Magazine](#) 28 December 2023.*

## America's Reckoning: The Search for Humanity in a Time of Genocide

ELAHEH FARMAND

As a 35-year-old Iranian woman, a citizen of the United States, an occupier of the indigenous land of Lenapehoking (Lënapehòkink), and as a human, I have never found life as extraordinarily grim and dark as I find it today.

I have stories of loss and grief embedded in my heart and have inked on my skin the names of my mother's family: one murdered by the former Shah (king) of Iran's secret police SAVAK, and two others executed by the Khomeini regime, all in the fight for a liberated Iran.

My family has told me about war sirens that sent them sheltering in the basement of our apartment building. I was born in 1987, eight months before the end of the eight-year war between Iran and Iraq—a war in which the U.S. provided military support to Saddam Hussein in Iraq to prevent Khomeini's regime from gaining support in Iran, only to later, in 2003, declare war on Saddam's regime, based on a fabricated claim that Iraq had weapons of mass destruction.

In America, I lived through the United States' illegal invasion of Iraq in ignorance: a middle schooler, adjusting and assimilating to American life as an immigrant. I lived oblivious to what was happening in the world, focused primarily on improving my English and finding my identity. I was bothered and knew that there was something deeply wrong. However, I had no capacity for, nor interest in, political analysis. Only in adulthood would I fully grasp the disastrous consequences of America's actions and the campaign of the "War on Terror", a war that cost 2.4 million Iraqi lives since the 2003 invasion.

The America that my mother dreamt of when she cooked in our kitchen in Tehran, and later when she awaited possible execution in Iran's Evin Prison; the America that my father sought refuge in; the America that has been our home for nearly 24 years, has broken my heart in unmendable ways. My heart broke when Trump was elected and opened America's Pandora's Box of racism, of degrading rhetoric and actions toward women, and non-white communities, particularly immigrants. My heart broke when I learned that Obama used drones to murder brown bodies. It broke when I learned that Hillary Clinton could not be a feminist because she spent her career advocating for war. It breaks every time there is a preventable mass shooting. It breaks every time there is another black body murdered by police.

But today's heartbreak feels as though it may never recover. Today, humans of conscience in my community have been taking to the streets of the Lehigh Valley and Washington D.C., chanting for a free Palestine, and calling for an end to genocide and Israel's apartheid system. People across the States and the globe are standing in solidarity for Palestinian liberation. Organizers, including students, are leading walk-outs and die-ins in protest, only to be suspended, censored, and arrested.

How grim and sad to know that our administration and most of its "leadership" choose indifference as their attitude toward the lives of Palestinians. How grim that our president unconditionally supports Israel without ever holding it accountable for its decades of indiscriminate persecution and imprisonment of the nation of Palestinian people, whose land it illegally occupies.

How grim and sad to be in America today having to demonstrate and protest and justify why Palestinian lives matter, and that what is happening is unequivocally genocide. How many voices and cries must those in power hear before they are convinced? How many more dead bodies must they see to believe that what we are witnessing is a crime against humanity?

How grim and sad it is to be in America today listening to "leaders" extend "humanitarian aid" or a "humanitarian pause," while simultaneously sending billions of dollars in weapons to Israel: American-made bombs are shredding children to pieces. This is what our tax dollars are funding.

Our "leaders" dictate to the masses which victims are worthy of our moral outcry: John Kirby, US National Security Council Coordinator for Strategic Communications, teared up over Ukrainian lives lost. Yet neither Kirby nor our president has shown the same outpouring of support or emotion toward Palestinian lives. President Biden has dismissed reports of Palestinian deaths.

Why can't we cry for all humans on this earth? Why do those in power call attention in support of women's rights in Iran but disregard women's rights in Palestine? Palestinian women are giving birth via emergency C-sections without anesthesia. They have no clean water. They cannot even take refuge in hospitals. These women witness the daily massacre of their children and loved ones. These women are forced to be refugees, and homeless. What about the rights of these women?

How can our "leaders" justify these killings when Israel uses bombs that burn people alive because the fires cannot be extinguished with water? Bombings that human rights organizations across the world say are undoubtedly war crimes.

Half of Gaza's population is under the age of 18. Every ten minutes, with our government's full backing, a child is killed in Gaza. As the children sleep, their homes may come tumbling down, crushing them, and trapping them under the rubble. Fathers and brothers fail to rescue them.

What has happened to our humanity?

America must reckon with its deep-seated racism and its history as a colonial project. Will it ever do so? Not unless the people, we, demand it. It's up to us to inspire this reckoning. We must look within ourselves and uproot our racism and ignorance of other nations, cultures, and religions. We must do the hard work of rekindling our humanity and then demanding it from those we elect to power.

While we do the work, while we take to the streets and disrupt business as usual, a ceasefire is the bare minimum to stopping this atrocity.

*Elaheh Farmand is an Iranian immigrant and writer. In 2016, she founded the series, "Immigrants & Exile: Stories of Nostalgia & Longing". The series gives space for people to share their experiences of nostalgia, exile, and longing. Elaheh fights for and dreams of a society restructured to place people's needs and wellbeing before profits. She is occasionally nostalgic for her childhood in Iran, but focuses her energy on organizing, connecting with her community, her family and friends.*

# But Do You Condemn Them?

IDRIS SETTLES

We see your people murdered  
Time and time again  
And we watch your children suffer  
But do you condemn them?

We are witnessing injustice  
Against your women and your men  
We see it with our own eyes  
But do you condemn them?

For decades you've been wronged  
This didn't just begin  
We hear about your struggle  
But do you condemn them?

You're submerged in darkness  
A deep place where you can't swim  
And we hear your cry for help  
But do you condemn them?

We see light shine from your people  
But we downplay it as dim  
We're really jealous of your courage  
But do you condemn them?

The hypocrisy of our ways  
Sticks out just like a stem  
And we never fail to ask you  
"But do you condemn them?"

We praise our president  
Your oppressors get support from him  
We know this to be unfair  
But do you condemn them?

Your hope for all humanity  
Is starting to look so slim  
We have the power to help you  
But do you condemn them?

Your land which is so sacred  
And precious like a gem  
Is being taken from you  
But do you condemn them?

We aren't helping you now  
And we didn't help back then  
We know it's a stupid question  
But do you condemn them?

You don't ask for much  
Just for the occupation to end  
That land has belonged to you  
But do you condemn them?

We claim we can't help you  
But take your enemies as our friend  
We reject calls for ceasefire  
But do you condemn them?

We justify the killing  
Claiming that's not what they "intend"  
We can't escape the truth  
But do you condemn them?

We send billions to your attackers  
So we must have lots to spend  
We deflect responsibility  
But do you condemn them?

We say we can't do much  
All we do is pretend  
We're on the wrong side of history  
But do you condemn them?

We never have an answer  
Against these claims we can't defend  
So as a copout we wonder  
"But do you condemn them?"

It's not like us to do what's right  
Something you can't comprehend  
We couldn't tell you ourselves  
But do you condemn them?

We're supporting a genocide  
A fact that we fail to contend  
And while this is true, we want to know  
"But do you condemn them?"

*Idris is a sophomore at Lehigh Carbon Community College.*



## Scrolling Through Genocide

STEVE SALAITA

**Z**ionist massacres are livestreamed to the masses in high definition and still nobody can stop them.

Not so long ago there was a common theory to which I subscribed: that in an era of mass media and instant streaming the Zionist entity is unable to fully displace or wantonly slaughter Palestinians because of the scrutiny it would invite. You can get away with a lot worse, the thinking goes, if nobody is watching.

It's a theory I've considered over the years while working in the fields of Native American and Indigenous Studies. From the beginning of this work, over 25 years ago, interlocutors stressed the importance of differences in comparative analyses. One crucial difference between Euro-American and Zionist colonization, everyone agreed, was the timeline. While colonization is ongoing in North and South America, often in situations of great struggle or tension, settlement of the so-called New World precedes the conquest of modern Palestine by a few centuries.

Those few centuries account for significant developments in jurisprudence, technology, communications, rhetoric, mobility, demographics, and diplomacy. Certain of these developments abet Zionist colonization, but others create limitations that Euro-Americans didn't need to worry over—global outrage or international law, for example.

The other notable difference is one of scale. Even limiting ourselves to the borders of the contiguous United States, the landmass subject to Euro-American settlement is much larger than historic Palestine (along with the surrounding areas that Zionists fantasize about). Variations of geography force us to think about the impact of physical space on conquest, and, in North America, the intricacies of conquest involving hundreds of nations.

The points of comparison nevertheless grow stronger with time.

For instance, it has become clear during the past two months in the Gaza Strip that the Zionist entity is plenty capable of equaling the belligerence of the American frontier, an era of wholesale ethnic cleansing thought to be a feature of history. ("It could never happen today," people sometimes would foolishly declare.) Colonial atrocities of the past—Wounded Knee, Sand Creek, the Trail of Tears—are now everywhere in evidence. The Zionist entity is carrying out a kind of primitive violence with modern technology.

This violence fills our computer and television screens. People around the world get minute-by-minute accounts of massive destruction and widespread murder. Certain images have become horrifyingly familiar: throngs of refugees queuing for bread; ambulances dodging tank and machine gun fire; hospitals in disarray; once-dense neighborhoods transformed by aerial bombardment into kilometers of rubble. We scroll through photos of men blindfolded and stripped to their underwear, lined up on the ground like antiquities in a museum courtyard. The scrolling continues

into pictures of white body bags in shallow trenches and then into videos of little girls and boys screaming trauma into the ruins of their childhood. We are perhaps the first generation to witness genocide in real time. History books about the horrors of the past are written every time somebody opens social media.

The theory that bearing witness will curtail Israel's ability to act on exterminationist fantasies no longer holds. Information and knowledge, it turns out, aren't reliable bulwarks against genocide. Impunity isn't beholden to disapproval.

What does it tell us that the Zionist entity can conduct this genocide in high definition, with no credible deniability and amid condemnation from all corners of the world?

It tells us that people serious about Palestinian liberation were right to despise the so-called radicals who laundered Zionism through celebrity activism, academic credentialism, NGO astroturf, and the Democratic Party. An entire class of influencers arose from Bernie Sanders' failed presidential campaigns. They populate hundreds of podcasts and livestreams. They wasted incalculable energy and resources promoting a man who would go on to repeatedly justify the bloody campaign in Gaza. Now they deplore Sanders after having extracted all the clout appended to his name and having ostracized the outliers who accurately tagged him as a fraud from the get-go. It was the most noteworthy example of a timeworn practice: pursuing access to microphones and *New Yorker* profiles by subsuming Palestinian liberation to institutions constitutionally hostile to revolutionary politics.

It tells us that international governing bodies and legal institutions are at best useless. Despite some halfhearted hemming and hawing, the UN has been an accomplice to the Zionist entity's genocide. The ICC will never see an American, Israeli, or EU war criminal on its docket. The Arab League pretends to care, but its performance is entirely unconvincing. Such institutions have been captured by imperialism since their inception.

It tells us that "dialogue" was always a pathway to submission. The idea that Israelis and Palestinians should dialogue as a means to peace was always dubious if only because dialogue can't work in situations of disparate power. But now, with Israelis overwhelmingly in favor of the genocide, it should be clear that Palestinians never had anyone to dialogue with in the first place.

It tells us that Western academe was completely unprepared for the material demands of decolonization despite its popularity as a professional brand. Many among the intellectual class, including scholars of Fanon like [Adam Shatz](#) and [Lewis Gordon](#), either disavow or diminish anticolonial resistance or ignore it altogether. Academe is where resistance goes for processing and beautification after it has been completed. It's rarely a place for the organizing stage.

It tells us that deterrence isn't a game of strategy played by eggheads on the internet, but an onerous project conditional on guns and rockets. Academics generally are too scared to say it, or, in an object lesson on arrogance, don't actually believe it, but a cache of weapons will always be more important than a conference panel.

It tells us that electoralism is a sham. There is no meaningful ideological variance among U.S. politicians at the national level. In practice, they range from center-right to fascist. In the upcoming presidential election, for example, voters will get

to decide between two scarcely-functional old farts with histories of sexual misconduct and a complete devotion to Zionist genocide.

It tells us that racism isn't simply an attitude, for its origin is social violence and eventually it will become physically violent in order to perform its civic mandate. In the framework of settler colonization, racism manifests as a yearning for cultural purification through displacement of the native.

It tells us that capitalism makes death a valuable commodity. The Zionist entity isn't merely an imperialist beachhead; it is a major player in the international weapons trade. It tests new munitions, chemicals, and surveillance technology on Palestinians. It arms reactionary forces throughout the Global South. It serves as a conduit and accomplice to U.S. policing. Because of Zionist occupation, corporations enjoy the use of human subjects as raw material for development and innovation.

It tells us that we wasted a whole lot of time trying to convince the oppressor that we are worthy of life when the oppressor cannot live without our extinction.

More than anything, it tells us that in the benighted West there is no democracy, no free speech, no legislative remedy, no human rights, no right even to be human. These are illusions people repeat in an effort to survive pervasive depravity, or myths they cynically invoke to gather the crumbs of deprivation. There is a ruling class and various iterations of the dispossessed and the dispossessed exist only to serve ruling class gluttony.

That's why countless people can deplore a genocide zoomed into our personal devices without being able to stop it. We are not simply ineffectual in the world of policymaking; policymakers are taunting us with their depravity.

What can we do, then? It's important to start by recognizing that the entire political class, from presidents to online pundits, has no regard for us—detests us, in fact—and is therefore never a reliable source of empathy or relief. Denizens of this class do not want our feedback; they want us to scroll through the debris of their malevolence.

Upon this recognition, the possibilities become clearer, albeit less convenient. But in the spirit of urgency, we can keep it simple: whether it happens in darkness or light, on screen or off, the Zionist entity needs to become an archive we browse as a cautionary tale, or else our future on this planet will be history.

*This piece first appeared at [www.stevesalaita.com](http://www.stevesalaita.com) on 10 Dec. 2023.*

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## 'From the river to the sea'—a Palestinian historian explores the meaning and intent of scrutinized slogan

MAHA NASSAR

What does the call "[From the river to the sea](#), Palestine will be free" mean to Palestinians who say it? And why do they keep using the slogan despite the controversy that surrounds its use?

As both a [scholar of Palestinian history](#) and someone from the Palestinian diaspora, I have observed the decades-old phrase gain new life—and scrutiny—in the massive pro-Palestinian marches [in the U.S.](#) and [around the world](#) that have occurred during the Israeli bombing campaign in the Gaza Strip in retaliation for Hamas' Oct. 7 attack on Israel.

Pro-Israel groups, including the U.S.-based [Anti-Defamation League](#), have labeled [the phrase "antisemitic."](#) It has even led to a [rare censure of House Rep. Rashida Tlaib](#), the only Palestinian-American member of Congress, for using the phrase.

But to Tlaib, and countless others, the phrase isn't antisemitic at all. Rather, it is, [in Tlaib's words](#), "an aspirational call for freedom, human rights and peaceful coexistence."

I cannot speak to what is in the heart of every person who uses the phrase. But I can speak to what the phrase has meant to various groups of Palestinians throughout history, and the intent behind most people who use it today.

Simply put, the majority of Palestinians who use this phrase do so because they believe that, in 10 short words, it sums up their personal ties, their national rights and their vision for the land they call Palestine. And while attempts to police the slogan's use may come from a place of genuine concern, there is a risk that tarring the slogan as antisemitic—and therefore beyond the pale—taps into a longer history of [attempts to silence Palestinian voices](#).

### An expression of personal ties

One reason for the phrase's appeal is that it speaks to Palestinians' deep personal ties to the land. They have long [identified themselves](#)—and one another—by the town or village in Palestine from which they came.

And those places stretched across the land, from Jericho and Safed near the Jordan River in the east, to Jaffa and Haifa on the shores of the Mediterranean Sea in the west.

These deeply personal ties were passed down over generations through [clothing](#), [cuisine](#) and subtle differences in [Arabic dialects](#) that are specific to locations within Palestine.

And those ties continue today. Children and grandchildren of Palestinian refugees often feel a [personal connection](#) to the specific places their ancestors hailed from.

## A demand for national rights

But the phrase is not simply a reference to geography. It's political.

"From the river to the sea" also seeks to reaffirm Palestinians' national rights over their homeland and a desire for a unified Palestine to form the basis of an independent state.

When Palestine was under [British colonial rule](#) from 1917 to 1948, its Arab inhabitants objected strongly to partition proposals advocated by British and Zionist interests. That's because, buried deep in the proposals, were [stipulations that would have forced](#) hundreds of thousands of Palestinian Arabs off their ancestral lands.

In 1946, the Delegation of Arab Governments [proposed instead](#) a "unitary state" with a "democratic constitution" that would guarantee "freedom of religious practice" for all and would recognize "the right of Jews to employ the Hebrew language as a second official language."

The following year, the United Nations instead approved a partition plan for Palestine, which would have forced 500,000 Palestinian Arabs living in the proposed Jewish state to [choose between](#) living as a minority in their own country or leaving.

It's in this context that the call for a unified, independent Palestine emerges, [according to](#) Arabic scholar Elliott Colla.

During the 1948 war that led to the formation of the state of Israel, [around 750,000 Palestinian Arabs](#) fled or were expelled from their villages and towns. By the end of the war, Palestine was [split into three](#): 78% of the land became part of the Jewish state of Israel, while the remainder fell under Jordanian or Egyptian rule.

Palestinian refugees believed they had a [right to return](#) to their homes in the new state of Israel. Israeli leaders, seeking to maintain the state's Jewish majority, [sought to have the refugees resettled](#) far away. Meanwhile, a narrative [emerged in the West in the 1950s claiming](#) that Palestinians' political claims were invalid.

## Future vision

Palestinians had to find a way to both assert their national rights and lay out an alternative vision for peace. After Israel occupied the West Bank, East Jerusalem and Gaza Strip in the 1967 Arab-Israeli War, the call for a free Palestine "from the river to the sea" started to [gain traction](#) among those who believed that all the land should be returned to the Palestinians.

But it soon also came to represent the vision of a [secular democratic state](#) with equality for all.

In 1969, the Palestinian National Council, the highest decision-making body of the Palestinians in exile, [formally called for](#) a "Palestinian democratic state" that would be "free of all forms of religious and social discrimination."

This remained a popular vision among Palestinians, even as some of their leaders inched toward the idea of establishing a truncated Palestinian state alongside Israel in the West Bank, Gaza Strip and East Jerusalem.

Many Palestinians were skeptical of this two-state solution. For refugees exiled since 1948, a two-state solution would not allow them to return to their towns and villages in Israel. Some [Palestinian citizens of Israel feared](#) that a two-state solution would leave them even more isolated as an Arab minority in a Jewish state.

Even Palestinians in the West Bank and Gaza Strip—those who stood the most to gain from a two-state solution—were lukewarm to the idea. A 1986 [poll found](#) that 78% of respondents "supported the establishment of a democratic-secular Palestinian state encompassing all of Palestine," while only 17% supported two states.

That helps explain why the call for a free Palestine "from the river to the sea" became popular in the [protest chants](#) of the First Intifada, or Palestinian uprising, from 1987 to 1992.

Notably, Hamas, an Islamist party founded in 1987, did not initially use "from the river to the sea," likely due to the phrase's long-standing ties to Palestinian secular nationalism.

## Two states or one?

The 1993 signing of the [Oslo Accords](#) led many to believe that a two-state solution was just around the corner.

But as hopes for a two-state solution dimmed, some Palestinians returned to the idea of a [single, democratic state](#) from the river to the sea.

Meanwhile, Hamas picked up the slogan, adding the phrase "from the river to the sea" to its 2017 [revised charter](#). The language was part of Hamas' broader [efforts](#) to gain legitimacy at the expense of its secular rival, Fatah, which was seen by many as having failed the Palestinian people.

Today, broad swaths of Palestinians still favor the idea of equality. A 2022 poll found [strong support](#) among Palestinians for the idea of a single state with equal rights for all.

## Offensive phrase?

Perhaps colored by Hamas' use of the phrase, some [have claimed](#) it is a genocidal call—the implication being that the slogan's end is calling for Palestine to be "free from Jews." It's understandable where such fears come from, given the Hamas attacks on Oct. 7 that killed [1,200 people](#), according to the Israeli foreign ministry.

But the Arabic original, "Filastin hurra," means liberated Palestine. "Free from" would be a different Arabic word altogether.

Other [critics of the slogan insist](#) that by denying Israel's right to exist as a Jewish state, the phrase itself is antisemitic. Under such thinking, protesters should instead be calling for a Palestinian state that exists alongside Israel—and not one that replaces it.

But this would seemingly ignore the current reality. There is [strong scholarly consensus](#) that a two-state solution is no longer viable. They argue that the extent of settlement building in the West Bank and the economic conditions in Gaza have eaten away at the cohesion and viability of any envisioned Palestinian state.

## Further demonization

There is another argument against the slogan's use: That while not antisemitic in itself, the fact that some Jewish people see it that way—and as such see it as a threat—is enough for people to abandon its use.

But such an argument would, I contend, privilege the feelings of one group over that of another. And it risks further [demonizing](#) and [silencing](#) Palestinian voices in the West.

Over the last month, Europe has seen what pro-Palestine advocates describe as an “[unprecedented crackdown](#)” on their activism. Meanwhile, people across the U.S. are reporting widespread [discrimination](#), [retaliation](#) and [punishment](#) for their pro-Palestinian views.

On Nov. 14, [George Washington University suspended](#) the student group Students for Justice in Palestine, in part because the group projected the slogan “Free Palestine From the River to the Sea” on the campus library.

### Principle, not platform

None of this is to say that the phrase “From the river to the sea, Palestine will be free” doesn’t have multiple interpretations.

Palestinians themselves are divided over the specific political outcome they wish to see in their homeland.

But that misses the point. Most Palestinians using this chant do not see it as advocating for a specific political platform or as belonging to a specific political group. Rather, the majority of people using the phrase see it as a principled vision of freedom and coexistence.

*This article first appeared in The Conversation on 16 Nov. 2023.*

*Maha Nassar is a historian, media critic, and author of [Brothers Apart: Palestinian Citizens of Israel and the Arab World](#).*

“...when Muslims and Arabs in America defend the rights of Palestinians or criticize Israeli state policy, they are often baselessly presumed to be motivated by a hatred for Jews rather than support for human rights, freedom, and consistent enforcement of international law. The resulting harm occurs at the individual and systemic level.”

*Center for Security, Race and Rights (Rutgers University)  
“Presumptively Antisemitic”*

## What Does LandBack Have to Do with the War Against Palestine?

DON FITZ

As horrible as Zionist atrocities against Palestinians are, we must not forget the fact that they reflect events that have happened for decades and that will continue to happen. They are the current chapter in repeated parades of mass extermination which have characterize capitalism since its birth.

A recurring theme in the campaigns has been landgrabs, or the seizure of land occupied by people who have been living there for centuries or millennia. With this in mind, the Green Party of St. Louis (GP StL) decided to point to the strong connection between the criminal occupation of Palestine and the LandBack movement on its website, in its speeches and in its [flyers](#).

LandBack was introduced in 2018 by [Arnell Tailfeathers](#) of the Blackfoot Confederacy. The movement called for Native Americans in the US and Canada for to regain their [ancestral lands](#). The idea quickly spread to Mexico, Australia, New Zealand and even Fiji.

LandBack could easily encompass the 104 million [Adivasi](#) of India, Native cultures throughout Latin America, and peoples across Africa who have been driven out of their homes for corporate farming, fossil fuel extraction, and desecration of land for “green” energy minerals.

Today, there is no place more justified for LandBack than Palestine, where Israeli “settlers” (with military backing) have pushed them off their land and slaughtered them for generations.

According to the LandBack [manifesto](#) “Our struggle is interconnected with the struggles of all oppressed Peoples. It is a future where Black reparations and Indigenous LandBack coexist. We are the land.”

Going far beyond economics, LandBack sees land as tied to culture: regaining land is central to efforts by the colonized to assert their existence. It advocates decolonization, dismantling white supremacy, and reclaiming stewardship to save their land.

Palestinian efforts to regain their land can become a spark to mobilize LandBack across the globe.

### Whose Lives Matter?

Colonizers inevitably dehumanized their victims, whether enslaving Africans or thieving indigenous land. Racist slurs permeated the capitalist conquest of those they deemed “inferior.”

One of the current dehumanization fads is saving the word “terrorist” for those who assert their human rights. Corporate media never portray the Israeli Defense Force as “terrorist,” although it has waged countless military attacks on Palestinians in the past 75 years. The only way that this makes sense is by assuming that “Palestinian Lives Do Not Matter.”

After a Benjamin Netanyahu aide [admitted](#) that Israeli forces targeted a hospital for over 500 murders to supposedly attack a Hamas base, Joe Biden swore his



support for Israel. He sides with Netanyahu no matter how many Palestinians Israel kills. Biden claims to be humanitarian while acting like “Palestinian Lives Do Not Matter.”

In 2024, the Green Party will field candidates advocating that “Palestinian Lives Matter.”

### Genocidal Landgrab of Palestine

Genocide of a people includes both their physical elimination and the extermination of their culture, their ways of living, their ties to the land, their customs, the things they hold sacred. US and Canadian “Indian schools” that forced children to cut their hair and speak English were just one way that Western powers have screeched at other peoples that their cultures are too worthless to be preserved.

The Balfour Declaration which set the stage for partitioning Palestine was based on the assumption that Israel would eventually drive out the people who lived there. It was a scheme for slow but certain genocide of Palestinians.

Biden is at least as guilty for committing genocide against Palestinians as is Netanyahu or Trump. All three join together to do whatever it takes to eliminate Palestinians and peoples across the globe who are in the way of landgrabs.

A vote for Biden is as much a vote for genocide as is a vote for Netanyahu. Voting for the Green Party is a vote to “Free, Free Palestine!”

### Palestine Is the World

Israel [teaches police](#) in other countries techniques for brutalizing their populations while the US media toys with molding public opinion by demonizing the victim as the criminal. The attack on Gaza is both a real time massacre and a dress rehearsal for crushing those who challenge Western hegemony or who live atop fossil fuels or minerals for alternative energy.

Struggles for human lives, freedom, and land are global. Palestine, Venezuela and Cuba are just three of the dozens of countries that the US is seeking to strangle via sanctions and invasions. In the 2024 elections the Republicans and Democrats will compete to see which can be more vicious.

The Green Party of St. Louis shows its dedication to human liberation by affirming the following: First, the current genocidal campaign against Palestine is not a “stand alone” issue. The Zionist slaughter is a part of the over 500 year efforts of colonial capitalism to destroy anyone who stands in the way of corporate economic growth.

Second, there cannot be “equal blame” for both sides. The solution for the crisis must begin with Israel’s withdrawing from occupied territories, acknowledging its criminal history, and providing reparations to its victims.

*A version of this article originally appeared in [Green Social Thought](#).*

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## Dubai Is a Fitting Host for the Climate Circus

SONALI KOLHATKAR

COP28 – In January 2023, nearly a year before the latest United Nations climate conference began, there was [deep concern and alarm](#) over the head of one of the world’s largest oil companies being appointed president of the [COP28 summit](#). The climate talks taking place in December 2023 were hosted by the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and overseen by Sultan Al Jaber, a man who happens to be in charge of the UAE’s national oil company Abu Dhabi National Oil Company. It’s a fitting illustration of an old idiom that the fox is in charge of the hen house.

Al Jaber’s appointment was such a clear conflict of interest that a group of United States lawmakers, including House Representatives Barbara Lee, Rashida Tlaib, and Jamaal Bowman, and Senators Bernie Sanders and Elizabeth Warren, sent a scathing [letter](#) on January 26th denouncing it. “Having a fossil fuel champion in charge of the world’s most important climate negotiations would be like having the CEO of a cigarette conglomerate in charge of global tobacco policy,” wrote the lawmakers.

Their warning fell on deaf ears and yet their fears proved to be correct months later when [The Guardian newspaper](#) published Al Jaber’s revealing remarks made at a November 2023 online climate meeting. Climate justice leader and former President of Ireland, Mary Robinson, rightly pointed out that the climate crisis was hurting women and children, and that Al Jaber had the power to do something about it. The oil company head angrily retorted that her comments were “alarmist,” and asserted that, “There is no science out there, or no scenario out there, that says that the phase-out of fossil fuel is what’s going to achieve 1.5C.”

He went on to [say](#), “Show me the roadmap for a phase-out of fossil fuel that will allow for sustainable socioeconomic development, unless you want to take the world back into caves.” Sounding defensive and cornered, Al Jaber added, “Show me the solutions. Stop the pointing of fingers. Stop it.”

Adding (fossil) fuel to the fire, the [BBC published an exposé](#) days before COP28 began revealing that “The United Arab Emirates planned to use its role as the host of UN climate talks as an opportunity to strike oil and gas deals.” UAE authorities did not deny the reports and instead responded with shocking hubris that “private meetings are private.”

Such shenanigans reveal the futility of relying on the UN’s annual COP meetings to phase out fossil fuels in order to stave off catastrophic climate change. Whereas earlier COP meetings fixated on the goal of “net zero emissions”—a phrase that climate activists rightly denounced as [greenwashing and propaganda](#)—the favorite phrase at this year’s COP28 appeared to be a [“phase down”](#) of fossil fuels.

The idea is that oil and gas producers may consider, someday in the far future, to start producing fewer fossil fuels than they do now. “Phase down” is a clever dilution of “phase out.” It is a sleight of hand intended to assuage concern over the warming climate all while remaining on a path to climate destruction.



The first draft of the COP28 agreement spelled out the two terms as interchangeable, referring to a “[phasedown/out](#).” Al Jaber reflected this equation of two different words even as he sought to maintain his credentials as head of COP28, saying that he has maintained “over and over that the phase-down and the phase-out of fossil fuel is inevitable.”

That Al Jaber would engage in trickery to protect fossil fuels is hardly surprising given his role as head of the Abu-Dhabi-based oil firm. In his [leaked remarks to Robinson](#), he proclaimed that phasing out oil and gas was not feasible, “unless you want to take the world back into caves.”

But it is precisely the continued use of fossil fuels that may take us back to the stone age. We may all be living in caves someday, seeking high ground from the rising waters of the warming oceans, all while Al Jaber and his ilk are ensconced in the [luxury bunkers of the wealthy](#).

It is an image that reflects the reality of Dubai, a [gleaming, futuristic city](#) where the Emirates pays lip service to climate progress as host of COP28, while simultaneously conspiring to secure oil and gas deals on the side. It’s a city that is defined by yet another idiom: trying to have your cake and eat it too.

I know, because I was born and raised in Dubai, a child of Indians who emigrated in 1970 to a land known as the [Trucial Sheikhdoms](#)—one year before they formally emerged as a single sovereign nation called the United Arab Emirates. My parents’ tenure in the UAE was older than the nation itself and while they toiled for more than 50 years as part of an immigrant workforce that outnumbers [Emiratis 9 to 1](#), they were never afforded citizenship, as were none of their three children born there.

The Emirates, with the blessing of its former colonial master [Britain](#), and its newer imperial partners, the [U.S.](#) and [Israel](#), has presided over an [oil-funded project](#) fueled by [exploited immigrant labor](#) to emerge as one of the most [important trading hubs](#) in the world: a [seductive tourist trap](#) dotted by [massive shopping malls](#) and [billboards](#) beneath which teeming [labor camps](#) invisibly keep the wheels of capitalism turning. It touts a liberalism that allows [women](#) to work, drive, and even hold limited leadership, all while suppressing the rights of low-wage [female domestic workers](#). It [pledges](#) sustainability while marketing itself to global investors.

It is hypocrisy manifested; a pretty façade of a promising future built on an age-old model of serfdom, a nation that celebrates the freedom to consume, but clamps down on the freedom to speak. In other words, it is a capitalist’s wet dream. What better place for fossil fuel promoters to pretend they care about the future of the planet?

The COP meetings have been a [disastrous distraction](#) from the urgent need to end fossil fuel production and consumption. Even [Christiana Figueres](#), former executive secretary of the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change, who is considered the architect of the 2015 Paris climate accord, is so disgusted by the state of proceedings that she called the COP “[a circus](#)”.

Having Dubai host the largest annual international climate gathering is a desperate bid by a dying industry to maintain relevance. [Energy forecasting predictions](#) point to a grim future for petrostates like the UAE. It’s no wonder Al Jaber has publicly tied himself into knots of contradictions. His nation’s future depends on the

continued flow of oil and gas, while our world’s future depends on an immediate termination of the poisonous fuels.

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## Degrowth – How Anti-Worker Would It Be?

DON FITZ

The year 2023 saw the [hottest Summer on record](#) in the northern hemisphere while those in the southern hemisphere felt the hottest winter on record. It was followed by a Fall with terrifying storms and floods across the globe. The number of people attributing climate catastrophe to [economic growth](#) is mounting.

Not all agree that growth is the problem. Some respond that growth is here to stay and that the concept of “degrowth” is idealistic nonsense.

Many of the accusations against degrowth have been answered. Jason Hickel’s [book](#) *Less Is More: How Degrowth Will Save the World* (2020) is perhaps the best known and most readable. An excellent collection of articles (Planned Degrowth and Sustainable Human Development) is available in the [July/August 2023](#) edition of *Monthly Review*.

### Is “Degrowth” Anti-Worker?

One accusation still seems to lack an adequate response: Is the US working class inherently anti-degrowth because it would mean a massive loss of jobs? This makes it appear that pro-growthers have never heard of a shorter work week. It would be the first consequence of degrowth. For many US workers, actually having a 40-hour work week would be welcome relief.

So, are workers inherently against degrowth? My family, friends and neighbors generally work for a living and not a single person has ever told me, “I would hate a shorter work week.”

One of the greatest problems for US workers is absence of health care as a human right. Despite the rantings of insurance company apologists, Medicare-for-All would cost much less. It is another way that degrowth would play out. In my [book](#) on Cuban Medical Care, *The Ongoing Revolution*, I document that Cubans have a longer life expectancy than do those in the US, while costs in Cuba are less than 10% per person per year of US costs.

Since the book was published, research has shown that Covid reduced [life expectancy](#) by almost three years in the US while it actually went slightly up in Cuba. A health system which focuses on preventive care, maternal care and childcare saves more lives and is vastly less expensive than one that focuses on insurance, providing too little care for those who need it most, giving too much treatment to some, over-medicating millions, and offering luxury hospital rooms.

No working person has ever said to me that “I want my elderly relatives to choose between treatment and food and I want super-expensive care that is less effective because that is what helps the economy grow.” With genuine degrowth, the cost for health care might not be just “less,” but could be much, much less and would result in longer lives.

There are several other things that I have never heard from working people...

I have never heard a truck driver say, “I want to buy things that fall apart quickly so I have to go out and buy another one that won’t work, go out of style or become obsolete. If products were built so that people could repair them themselves and would last a long time, that would mean fewer jobs; so, businesses should manufacture as much junk as possible.”

No secretary has told me, “I love food that travels for 2000+ miles before getting to me, has lost most of its nutritional value, and can contaminate everyone who eats it due to its chemical content. Having good food grown locally would mean fewer jobs.”

No grocery store checker has ever told me that he really wants packaging that costs almost as much as the product, banking with ever-increasing fees, insurance that does not pay when he needs it, and incessant advertising on TV, radio and billboards. These are just some of the ways that capitalism creates useless jobs which do not improve people’s lives and whose reduction or abolition would contribute to a shorter work week.

The other day an image of Dracula gazed at me as the phlebotomist put a rubber cord around my arm and I waited to hear if she would say, “I would hate having a smaller economy because that would mean that fewer people would get cancer from radiation and toxic chemicals. There would be fewer jobs from producing poisons and fewer jobs for every type of health care worker. I would be happy to increase cancer risks for myself, my family, and my neighbors if that means more jobs.” For some reason, those words were never spoken.

### Who Dislikes Degrowth?

So where are all these working people who passionately hate degrowth? They must be hiding behind a tree or underneath a bed because I have never run into them.

Actually, the claim that “working people are against degrowth” may well ring a bell for many. Those who work in armaments production as well as veterans and others who simply accept militaristic propaganda may be against degrowth because there is no way to degrow without massively shrinking the US military.

Degrowth means shifting resources to colonized peoples both inside the US and globally. The essence of degrowth is (a) decreasing useless and harmful production in rich countries, (b) increasing the production of necessities in poor countries, (c) while making sure that (a) is greater than (b). Growth does not and never has meant improving the quality of lives in the [poor world](#). In contrast, reparations are essential for degrowth.

Saying that degrowth would never happen because working people would be against it is not only wrong—it is unethical.

Abortion rights provide an illustration why. A majority of working people currently support women’s right to have an abortion. The reason to support abortion rights is not because most of labor is in agreement—the reason is that protecting women’s lives is the right thing to do (regardless of whether or not it is popular).

What does one do when confronting an opinion that does not jive with the mood-of-the-day? The movie *Matewan* portrayed a union organizer constantly struggling to overcome prejudices. He did not ignore them or kowtow to them.

Today, most progressives would agree that, when faced with those who hate Blacks or sympathize with efforts to eliminate Jews or Palestinians, it is necessary to confront them.

If it is good to challenge those who attack one group of humanity, then why would it be bad to challenge the destruction of all of humanity, as the ideology of infinite growth would set the stage for? Growth means expansion of fossil fuels, increased electronic colonialism (i.e. “alternative” energy), and extermination of Life on land, in the air and within the oceans.

### Who Are “The Workers?”

Two common mistakes about American workers are that they all think the same and that thinking is represented by union leaders. Anti-degrowththers often give the impression that they confuse the word “workers” with “unions.” At last count, only about 6% of US private sector workers are in unions and union members often disagree intensely with union officers.

Union history is a mixed bag of the most magnificent heroes to those who betray inter-ethnic and international labor solidarity. Certainly, the masses of union members did not ask or consent to their leaders collaborating with corporate executives to build “[Free Labor Development](#)” that would crush militant democratic unions internationally as Kim Scipes so carefully documents.

Portraying labor as having a uniform ideology is more than a little bit wrong. In addition to Democratic Party loyalists, “working people” includes millions who switch from one party to another, those who do not identify with any party, right-wing Trumpsters, and, yes, moderate, and revolutionary socialists and anarchists.

The UAW strike that began in September 2023 manifested a union waking out of its nearly century old Rip Van Winkle state to rediscover the demand for a [32 hour work week](#). Let us hope that this foreshadows a reawakening that spreads throughout labor, unorganized as well as organized.

### Capitalism without Exploitation?

“Bread and butter” unionism is dedicated to living with capitalism while getting a bigger piece of the pie. “Social unionism” challenges capitalism’s assumption that some should be vastly richer and more powerful than others.

Degrowth will require redefining every aspect of the economy, beginning with the length of the work week and extending to what is produced and relationships between those involved in production. Unionism that accepts capitalism as eternal would be poorly suited to such a task. Unionism that proudly announces its goal to be building a new world from the ashes of the old would be the cat’s meow.

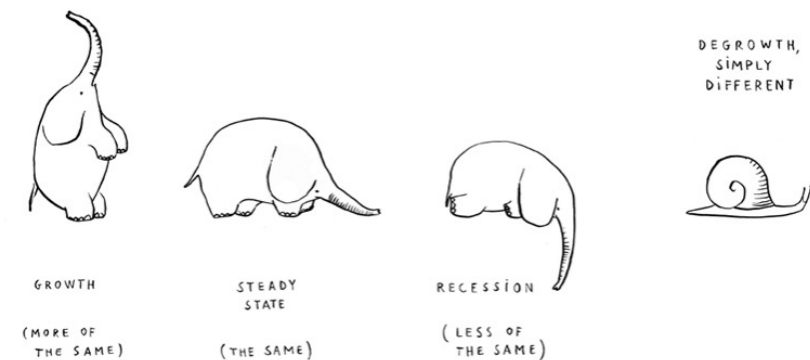
You may have heard of the Industrial Workers of the World (IWW). Ever since 1905 it has consistently sought to unify all working people, not just in the US, but across the globe. Perhaps it is time for existing unions to either emulate the IWW or be replaced by it or other solidarity unions that will seek to liberate humanity from the chains of corporate growth, whether they reside in the imperialist homeland or the colonized world.

Proposing growth without racist colonialism makes as little sense as advocating capitalism without [exploitation](#). Colonialism was the method by which corporations amassed the “primitive accumulation of capital” which Marx wrote about.

Belief that the economy must grow assumes the eternal existence of capitalism. Genuine degrowth means reorganizing society so that destructive and useless production is brought to an end while protecting the well-being of all involved in affected industries. A total redesign of society could begin with a shorter work week and then expand to establishing new relationships, whether in an office or at a health facility or a factory. For the working class to take control of the economy and metamorphose it will be degrowth realized.

Is it time to ask if the concept of growth is what is inherently anti-worker? A shorter work week is the rock on which degrowth stands. If not that rock, it is the name of the rock that David put into his sling and hurled into the head of the corporate system called “Goliath.”

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## Noam Chomsky at 95: No Strings on Him

MICHAEL ALBERT

*“A habit of basing convictions upon evidence, and of giving to them only that degree of certainty which the evidence warrants.”—Bertrand Russell*

*“Justice will not come until those who are not injured are as outraged as those who are.”—Solon 560 BC*

Sometimes a voice reverberates across space and time. Sometimes a voice feels missing somewhere, sometime. Sometimes a voice does both, simultaneously, forever.

For all the famous people who passed through MIT during my student stay there, or whom I have known in any other capacity since, or even who I have ever read from or read about, for all the great achievers who ever made a difference anywhere anytime, to my life the most important has been Noam Chomsky. His example has illuminated many paths that I and countless others have tried to navigate. Instead of throwing piddling pebbles at a giant, I prefer to just say thank you. And happy birthday, Noam, December 7. 95! Whatever befalls, may you be for us all, forever young.

I met Noam when I took his course “Intellectuals and Social Change” at MIT where I was a student. It was the sixties, and we became friends—me a student, he a mentor nineteen years my senior, and, please take note, at that time nineteen years was a veritable lifetime—and yet we have stayed close for six decades since.

I have often heard people ask Noam “what makes you so productive?” I have often heard him fluster a bit and then reply that the only thing he could see in his makeup that seemed different from most other people was that he could sit down at a project after having been away for a time and on returning get immediately back in gear. Other writers—I well know—typically waste time rereading and reintegrating when we return to projects that we earlier set aside for even just a day much less longer. But despite the surprising wisdom of his simple answer, I saw in Noam more defining differences than just that.

For nearly sixty years I have quite often enjoyed Noam’s input on and aid to my work and have occasionally even offered some ill-informed reactions to his. I have seen him in all kinds of interactions and shared all kinds of moments with him, personal and political, social and private, on stage and off. It has been a highlight of my life to not only have had Noam as a friend and guide, but also to have learned from and enjoyed so many of his stories and undertakings. It hasn’t even been annoying that whenever I have gone someplace to speak, from Florida to Ohio, New York to Alaska, Greece to Brazil, England to India, Poland to Australia, and Korea to Venezuela, invariably considerable time has gone to answering questions about Noam. How is Noam doing? Is Noam really an anarchist? What does Noam think about the invasion? Why did Noam say that stuff about Cambodia? How does Noam do it? How does Noam do it? How does Noam do it? And even, sometimes, can you explain

Noam’s linguistics? Noam’s shine extends to everywhere. Literally everywhere. His voice reverberates. So here are a few snapshot answers about the incredible, the good, the problematic, and the incandescent I have had the privilege of seeing firsthand.

Lydia Sargent and I went to Poland in 1980. The trip occurred because South End Press had recently published the then young Polish writer Slawomir Magala’s book on the uprisings in his country and the emergence of the Polish Workers’ Party led by Lech Walesa. Lydia and I had gone for business at the International Book Fair in Frankfurt, Germany, and had then continued on to meet Magala to learn about events in Poland. I remember Lydia talking with a leftist General about feminism. He got woken. I also remember Lydia and I being in an apartment talking with Swavek—the author’s nickname—and a number of his friends. At one point, I was replying to some question about America, and the subject of Chomsky’s political writings came up. Later there was more general discussion, and as there was a linguist present, Chomsky’s linguistic theories came up for some airing. As I was telling my hosts a story about Chomsky the linguist, just as I had earlier relayed stories about Chomsky the politico, someone said, “Wait a minute, how could you know both Chomskys personally? That’s quite a coincidence.”

I started to chuckle but realized the questioner was serious. It turned out these activists, who were certainly among the most cosmopolitan people in Poland, nearly all thought that there was one Chomsky who was political and wrote books about history, Vietnam, and revolution, and there was another Chomsky who was a linguist and wrote books about grammar, cognition, and human nature. On reflection, I realized that though I initially found the question weird, it was actually quite reasonable. After all, wasn’t it more likely that two people would share one name than that one person would have two incredibly stellar but thoroughly unconnected careers. So first, what makes Chomsky so insightful and productive? Second, what makes Chomsky so admirable?

Partly Chomsky’s insightfulness and productivity were inborn. But genetic endowment, while obviously desirable, isn’t something we should praise and can’t be emulated. We can be awed by Usain Bolt’s incomparable speed, Fyodor Dostoevsky’s magical prose, Adele’s emotive voice, Einstein’s physical intuition, Martin Luther King’s speechifying brilliance, Dylan’s transcendent lyrics, and Emmy Noether’s mathematical creativity. We can enjoy seeing such traits at work. We can be wowed by them. We can be fascinated and enlightened by them. We can even be inspired by them. But it doesn’t make sense to say that the owner is worthy of special respect, admiration, or emulation based simply on having been born with special abilities.

Noam’s special memory could retain both broad strokes and also fine detail with computer-like recall. Everyone’s memory tends to decline with age, even Noam’s, but even at seventy-five and then eighty five, and now ninety five Noam’s memory dazzles. In the 1960s, in that course of his that I took, Noam would routinely give references from books he’d read and if asked would sometimes even refer to a page, or sometimes even a part of a page. But Noam’s memory was by no means photographic, just profound, and even then, only for things he found important. At speaking engagements people would query all manner of important topics completely off his assigned speaking agenda, and Noam would almost always reply with in depth



information whose range and precision in a field other than his own even experts in that other subject would marvel at. I saw this happen over and over with questions regarding prevailing conditions in countries he was visiting and also regarding ideas in linguistics, philosophy, history, cognitive science, and biological science. So, really, four and a half decades after the conversation in Poland—one, two, or many Noams? Judge for yourself. You can see such exchanges on YouTube anytime you wish.

Second, consider Noam's rapid and clear thinking. If he was a physicist, say, or a mathematician, we could better judge this in-born part of his capacity as only incredibly substantial, like for most any great scientist, or as out-right phenomenal, like for von Neumann or Feynman. But another Noam trait had inborn but also had trained aspects that emerged from his effort and discipline. Noam routinely extricates himself from habit and familiarity to consider possibilities strikingly different than what most people contemplate. It isn't just that he would imbibe a wealth of data or make connections and test logical possibilities that would exceed other people's capacities. Others born even with great memory and quick minds mostly just collect, enumerate, and detail what is known, or perhaps discover a new fact, or very occasionally even a new connection, but they don't repeatedly generate dramatically new insights that repeatedly transform a whole discipline. Again, visit YouTube. You can watch Noam repeatedly ask unexpected questions. He operates way outside every box. He entertains the otherwise unseen possibility. He sees the hidden connection.

Think of Einstein. What Einstein did that was phenomenal was to extract general physical truths from snippets of physical reality to generate previously unknown insights. To think about what would happen if someone ran alongside a light ray, or to think through the dynamics of a falling elevator, two of Einstein's guiding thought experiments, didn't require tremendous calculating capacity. Einstein didn't have to follow a logical train of thought through countless complicated steps. The genius Einstein exhibited was often not in the number of steps in his deductions, nor in their technical difficulty to compute. His genius was in undertaking the key steps at all and in then following them down paths that others didn't even notice or didn't dare traverse. His genius was in his leaps off the beaten path. Einstein's frequent way to leap was what scientists call thought experiments. These mental gymnastics pared away reality's inessential contingent details to better highlight its deepest core meanings. To do this, Einstein envisioned unattainable contexts and rendered them pure and pristine inside his head by removing endless detail. Then he turned the essence inside out and upside down until he had a new explanation.

One way Noam has innovated has been by employing analogies (more or less like thought experiments) far more often and far more effectively than other people do. Noam would take a familiar situation—and this is a trait that we can learn from and try to emulate—and find another that was structurally like the first but regarding which his (and our) habits and biases would operate less powerfully or not at all. He would use this technique both to successfully communicate to reticent audiences assessments that if he had initially offered them about the first situation would have affronted people and been ward off by their prior prejudices or expectations—and he also used such context switching, I suspect, to himself discover new views. He did this magic by analyzing the structurally similar but less-controversial and less-famil-

iar situation that he invented or that he remembered in analogy, and then showing himself (or us) the meaning the aloof setting held for the emotionally fraught setting whose implications were obstructed by preconceptions.

Physicists abstract away countless details, assume all kinds of simplifications that are in the real world unattainable, and view in their mind's eye what occurs in the imagined simpler world to discern innermost real-world dynamics without letting endless cluttering facts and personal prejudices obscure the deep truth. Noam's analogy trick is similar, but it is more suited to the realm of worldly affairs, though I would guess that regarding linguistics he probably also used both analogies and thought experiments, or perhaps a cross between the two. In Linguistics, for example, one breakthrough he made, and he authored a great many, came when he asked how babies could hear only a very few examples of communication and then fully speak and understand a language. He wondered what had to be innately inside the baby, all babies, but not squirrels or even dogs, to allow that.

The analogy technique Noam used can be found all through his social writings. He would switch from talking about the U.S. in Vietnam (then obscured by emotional preconceptions and prejudices that the U.S. could do no wrong) to the role of Russia in Eastern Europe (where an American could see invasion and imperialism more clearly). He would switch from discussing the possibility of a U.S. invasion of Afghanistan (which deeply held axiomatic U.S. beliefs biased against recognizing since the U.S. was never the bad invader) to the possibility of Iran invading Afghanistan (easier to conceive for someone from the U.S.). He would switch from assessing the criminality of the U.S. punishing Afghanistan's whole population for their country housing terrorists who attacked the U.S. (confused, after all, how could we be criminal) to Britain (if it had done so) punishing the U.S. for housing and financing IRA acts in Britain (easy to analyze since of course anyone else can be criminal). Or he would compare the media emphasizing 9/11 as terrorism but not seeing the U.S. embargo of Iraq as chemical and biological warfare waged on civilians. He would move from discussing U.S. media dynamics to discussing old Soviet media dynamics, or from discussing U.S. foreign policy to discussing the behavior of Mafia dons, and so on. The analogies would bypass confounding biases to reveal core features and then he would switch back to see them in more-difficult-to accept circumstances like scientists with thought experiments more generally.

Noam, like virtually all geniuses, also worked hard. Has he been driven, compulsive, and even over the top when it comes to work? By everyday standards, yes, arguably he has. If you named twenty prominent athletes, actors, and musicians over the past thirty years, Noam would probably have heard of two or three, or maybe five at most, and he would be able to offer essentially zero information about any of them. No memory for that. Noam would see maybe two or three movies a year. He would see a few hours of TV other than news a year. He would listen to almost no radio. He knew what he wanted to know, and in that realm his knowledge was incandescent.

Noam used to have a summer home in Wellfleet, Massachusetts. There was a motorboat and a small sailboat, and he and his then wife Carol lived on a lake in the summers and in a home in Lexington, Massachusetts the rest of the year. Over the course of each summer, he and Carol would get out on the ocean in either boat

barely more than a handful of times. They would visit the tiny beach of the lake they were alongside via a short walkway more often, including with guests, and Lydia and I were there many times. Mostly, though, Noam was ensconced in his study, reading and writing in the summer just like during the rest of the year. Hour upon hour he would read and write. Combine this diligence with his quick start ability and with very little editing needed since his writing winds up, I am guessing about this, pretty much the way it first comes out, and you get a lot of output, and actually you get way more output than most people familiar with either his political or his scientific production, or even with both, realize.

You see, Noam typically answered even short letters from unknown folks with long letters back to the extent of a small book's worth of correspondence each month. More, Noam revolutionized linguistics and what is called cognitive science—not once in a lifetime, but multiple times. Indeed, for decades at MIT, Noam taught a linguistics seminar each Friday that people came from near but also far just to attend. Why? Because each week Noam would present some original material that he had settled on in the prior week. This alone, even without his other involvements, was an unfathomable pace of production.

But meanwhile, there were other involvements. Another Noam churned out scathing denunciations of U.S. foreign policy, excoriated mainstream media machinations, and comprehensively clarified diverse political phenomena. Noam spoke publicly dozens of times a year and wherever he went he would address that place's history and current events with almost the same incredible precision and innovation as he would offer about the U.S. Noam's talks often continued for hours. He did countless interviews, often a few each week. Each part of his life seemed virtually impossible, yet all the parts did happen, and they happened over and over. So, two, three, many Noam's?

Anyone's hard work is worthy of admiration though maybe in a desirable world no one would be quite as driven as Noam has been in our world. Indeed, in a desirable world, while Noam would still have worked tirelessly on his science out of the joy and accomplishment of it, he would undoubtedly have also been out sailing more often, weeding in his garden more often, and even laughing at movies more than he has done in our world. So, his sacrifice to take so much time to tirelessly reveal injustices merits admiration. But the most admirable Noam, it has always seemed to me, has been the scrupulously honest Noam. Noam is another name for integrity in enormous supply. The most admirable Noam respects but does not condescend to others. He cares.

Honesty is easy to understand. Noam always says what is on his mind, sometimes at a cost. Indeed, bad can come from good. Noam's unbreakable grip on the truth has interfered, at times, with other virtues, such as sensitivity to the impact his words might have on others. Assessing someone in Noam's position, I tend to think truth-telling should most often take precedence over what's called sensitivity but is sometimes little more than compromise or even hypocrisy—though others might disagree about this, and it certainly isn't one size fits all.

Integrity is harder to pin down. It presumably means being true to one's values, when one has values that one can be true to. Noam has had values and has been

true to them. This too can reach levels that cause problems. Noam eschewed anyone affecting the choices of another by anything other than logic and evidence. You can see the effects of this in his speaking style and in his writing, and it has caused Noam to be tremendously wary of and often even to deny his own notoriety. He has frequently worried that his words would be unduly attended by his listeners. This has often made Noam loathe to give advice to the point that he would withhold words that might usefully have been heard.

Respecting others had another kind of pitfall for Noam. He was constantly queried by people who were relatively ignorant of what they asked about. A person in a position like Noam's gets used to these kinds of questions. For Noam, respecting his questioners meant taking them seriously and answering honestly with patience and attention to communicating clearly. Noam did that, again at a level that closely examined might seem humanly impossible. Noam would receive letters out of the blue. Some would have ridiculous formulations or ask questions he had answered a thousand times. No matter. He would reply to everyone as if he was replying to a knowledgeable co-worker or to an interviewer chatting with him. But he also quite reasonably wanted such exchanges to move along and so a problem sometimes arose because Noam also means a very quick study.

When someone would start to ask Noam something familiar, sometimes Noam would tend to fill in the blanks. After hearing a few words, Noam would deduce the person's intent and interrupt to begin answering even before the person finished their question. This could on occasion sidetrack Noam from hearing what was actually being asked in the interests of saving time and even imposing accuracy when there were a bunch of people wanting his attention after a talk so that moving along and breadth of exchange were important. Experience edifies and so most often Noam actually helped questioners by making their questions more precise and complete. Other times, however, Noam would jump too quickly and misperceive the questioner's query due to thinking he recognized the questioner's point when in fact he didn't. In other words, sometimes a person querying Noam or disagreeing with him had a different point than those who had previously used essentially the same initial words. Noam might then miss this difference, thereby seeming to be oblivious to the person's true intents and insights. It was not pleasant when it happened to you, but it was never ill motivated.

To understand caring is hard. There are people who routinely verbally offer sympathy and concern for others—have a nice day, they say—but who, at least in my experience, don't sincerely give a damn. Something that looks and sounds like caring is present, and many people are very impressed by its appearance, but minutes or even seconds later the seeming concern could be gone. Appearance without essence has little or no staying power and few implications beyond false appearances. For Noam, the caring was less evident, less demonstrative, less of a show, but it lasted and had implications.

Noam believes strongly in civility though I think many people who have gotten into debates with him and had their views dissected—sometimes with words like “trivial” punctuating the dissection—would find a belief in civility hard to believe. But for Noam, calling a claim trivial is not uncivil but honest. It is a comment about

a thought and not a comment about the person who presented the thought. In this, Noam was a scientist in the sense that scientists routinely debate and mercilessly skewer one another's views. And scientists don't take offense at that, or even understand taking offense at that. Finding the truth and escaping falsehoods, which is the scientist's reason for being, demands this behavior. I have seen Noam publicly say an idea was dumb—not least some of mine—but I have never seen him publicly say a person was dumb.

Noam did not denigrate others to build himself up or to knock others down. Likewise, Noam did not evidence the kind of condescending and self-promoting or guilt-salving concern for others that is all too frequent in many circles. Noam's caring was real. There was no pomp or circumstance. He did not performatively weep wildly or gush effusively. And his caring didn't follow a line dictated from elsewhere but came from within. Noam remembered people's needs. He fulfilled requests. He noticed pain and tried to do real things to alleviate it. He was on time to not waste others' time. He was civil. You could even call Noam conservative in daily life characteristics. If there was a sign to stay off a lawn, Noam obeyed even if crossing the lawn would get him where he was looking to go faster. Indeed, I have watched Noam routinely abide almost all rules unless higher values took precedence. Noam is also another word for private. In fifty years, I have seen him voluntarily talk about what he considered purely personal matters only rarely. I think few have seen more.

For Noam's seventieth birthday, twenty-five years ago this December, as a present I arranged a kind of testimonial tribute. I put on the Internet a means by which people could write a message that Noam would receive in a bound volume on his birthday. About a thousand people entered messages online. Most of these were people who Noam had never closely or even at all known but who had read his work or heard him speak and been dramatically affected by him and just wanted to register their thanks. Many other contributors did know Noam, and they also wanted to say their piece to their friend, ally, student, teacher, coworker, or what have you.

As I assembled the uniformly emotional messages, the entry I was most moved by was written by Fred Branfman, who was himself a very effective advocate of human rights and a supporter of the Indochinese people against unimaginably callous U.S. violence. Branfman wrote: "When you visited me in Laos in 1970, I was at a real low point, anguished by the bombing and feeling almost totally isolated. Your passion, commitment, and shared pain about the need to stop the bombing, and warm, personal support and caring, meant more to me than you will ever know. It also meant a lot to me for reasons I can't quite explain that of the dozens and dozens of people I took out to the camps to interview the refugees from the bombing you were the only one, besides myself, to cry. Your subsequent article for the New York Review of Books and all the other writing and speaking you did on Laos, was also the only body of work that got it absolutely right. It has given me a little more faith in the species ever since to know that it has produced a being of so much integrity, passion, and intellect. I feel a lot of love for you on your birthday—and shake my head in amazement knowing that you'll never stop."

Noam and I have had a few arguments over the years. Noam can be world-class stubborn, even if not demonstrative or flailing about it. Then again is it stubborn when

you are right? Noam expected to be right because he almost always was right, and probably also because when he asserted something it wasn't reflex, he had thought seriously about it. But he also didn't like to be wrong. In his case, this may have been a bit like someone not liking to fall down when crossing a room, or not liking to slip in the tub. In other words, he didn't like to suffer something that was highly unfamiliar and also had a negative aspect. To some people this could feel annoying, frustrating, even hurtful. All in all, though, I have never known anyone smarter, with a better memory, with a greater facility for creatively escaping the bounds of acceptable thought, or, still more admirably, with more honesty, integrity, respect for others, real universal concern, and devotion to doing what needs doing. As with everyone, Noam is multi-sided. It is just that in Noam's journey there have been very few down sides, and the up sides have been huge. And would you believe, he is also a very funny guy.

Despite my managing to learn enough from Noam so I usually found myself agreeing with him, sometimes Noam and I would see what's out in the world a bit differently and feel responses ought to have slightly different attributes. A couple of times we had a still larger disagreement. Here are two, each of which reveals Noam attributes in their evolution, I think.

The first was about what we might call a crowding-out effect, borrowing that label from economists. Noam went out and spoke a huge amount to very large audiences. A great many venues wisely wanted Noam to come talk. Many fewer venues ignored many other available speakers who, while not as excellent as Noam, would be way more than ample. The result was that Noam talked a huge volume but even with his great frequency, many places would settle for no one other than Noam and so would have no speaker. An unintended consequence was that undeniably worthy speakers who lacked Noam's notoriety, wouldn't get invites they ought to have gotten because if invited they wouldn't attract sufficient audience. What to do?

Over the years, I urged Noam to tell those asking him to come speak that he would not do so unless there could be a second speaker on the bill with him whom he would select. Each time he would go out in that scenario, so too would Steve Shalom go, or Holly Sklar, or Cynthia Peters, or Peter Bohmer, or Clarence Lusane, or Robin Hahnel, and so on. In this way, others would be seen, word of mouth about the quality of their talks would spread, and in time those other people would get direct invitations. Then those additional people, having become better known, could themselves do the same thing, bringing still more speakers to visibility. After a bit, many more people, steadily more diverse in background and experience, would be going around speaking and many more talks would be given and heard.

Noam almost never did this, and we argued about it quite a few times. His resistance was partly ideological and partly personal. Ideologically, he didn't want to use his "bargaining power" to impose conditions on potential hosts—and he would also tend to deny that he could get a positive response by making such demands, which was humility trumping reality. He also, personally, I suspect, didn't overly want to share the stage with a co-speaker, since that would have himself traveling just as far, taking just as much time away from other work, but speaking and dealing with questions for a lot less time. I have myself since our earliest disagreements about this issue spoken publicly quite a lot though only a fraction as often as Noam, and in doing so I

have come to better understand his side of this dispute. Indeed, I came to understand and admire his not wanting to impose his will. And I also eventually got his not wanting to halve his airtime. I now think what's needed is not to get prominent speakers to place demands on hosts, but for speakers' bureaus to impose conditions on behalf of a community of speakers.

A second disagreement has been over matters of vision, economic mostly, but otherwise as well. This has been a debate and even dispute where I have to say that, again, with passing years while he moderated somewhat, I moderated more than somewhat. Noam felt way back that trying to describe a future society could and indeed would overstep existing bounds of knowledge. It might also crowd out creativity by establishing aims prematurely. And it might tend toward sectarianism. He felt broad values for a better future were all that we needed to offer, plus practice, practice, and more practice that would yield on the spot day-to-day innovations that would lead to implementing new ways of being from the bottom up. Noam felt that to pre-think and set forth institutional vision in advance could curb such exploration. I instead felt this was all well and good as fair warning about negative possibilities to watch for, except that after a few hundred years of such efforts, we should have something more to show. How could the lessons of thinking hard, analyzing, and experimenting become part of broad movements, I wondered, if they were not presented, debated, refined, and finally advocated by broad movements?

To me, it seemed obvious that we needed answers to the question "what do you want" that went well beyond just offering worthy values. We needed answers that could provide hope, direction, and a positive tone able to inform both analysis and strategy, and I thought this entailed more than offering only a list of broad values and aspirations. I thought it required institutional substance. Noam's concern, in contrast, was to ensure participation and to avoid elites emerging to impose a view on movements. I agreed with his aim, but I also felt we would get what Noam feared if we didn't have movements full of participants who understand, advocate, and continually refine a viable worthy vision able to motivate and orient sustained participation. The alternative to elitist vision, I thought, wasn't having no institutional vision at all, but having the most accessible, widely shared, compelling, and substantial but not over-detailed and in any event quite flexible institutional vision we could write up, debate, refine, and advocate. In short, I thought I was right. But as time passed, I arrived at greater awareness of the validity of Noam's concerns and the need to attend to them even as I still believed in the importance of having core institutional vision. The point? Even on the rare occasions when Noam wasn't totally right, even supposing this was such a case, he was always right enough to pay close attention to and not dismiss. That is—to disagree with Noam without very close consideration of his points and careful accommodation to them usually turns out to be quite foolish. In short, this guy is right even when he is wrong.

I remember a time in Noam's office in a wing of MIT ironically largely financed since WWII by the Pentagon. It was 1969 or thereabouts. Robin Hahnel and I were being recruited by the Weatherman organization. I asked Noam his advice. Remember, Noam didn't like providing personal life advice. He also felt he had little to offer about strategy and he didn't want his words over weighted. Double whammy on

answering. But in this case, he answered anyhow. He said, roughly, Michael, the Weather-people seem courageous and sincere, but they will blow up some stuff and perhaps themselves as well, and in doing so they will damage rather than aid change. Robin and I heeded his advice. Neither of us joined Weatherman.

I once wrote a piece propelled by the experience of reading Chomsky and its impact on people and in particular on me, and also by my wondering how Noam managed to constantly immerse himself in so much data about social pain and injustice without himself becoming jaded. It wasn't that his burrowing in the blood drenched tombs of injustice didn't take a toll. It did. There are times when Noam was brought low by the news he dissected and times when he was wired tight and became difficult. How family around him got through all that may be as amazing as some of Noam's accomplishments. At any rate, the essay I wrote fueled by these personal thoughts and of course also by the problem of changing the world was called "Stop the Killing Train." For me, it was an infrequent attempt at being poetic. Written in the lead-up to the first Gulf War, I think the essay is no less timely now than when it was first written precisely because lessons from Noam will never be anything less than timely. The message of that piece was that things all around are abysmal. Violence is even greater than it seems. Injustice is even more vile than it seems. The need to resist and seek better is evident and paramount. So don't bemoan, seek better. And perhaps that message, his message, is a good way to move on from discussing Noam per se, to noting what Noam would reply to this essay. He would tell me to stop talking about him and his life, but if you must do that, he might say, then at least draw lessons about the world as it is and as it can be.

So finally, about knowing Noam, I might echo what Bob Dylan had to say about Dave Van Ronk: "No puppet strings on him, ever. He was big, sky-high, and I looked up to him. He came from the land of giants."

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*Editor's Note: This is the text of Chapter 1 in Chris Gilbert's book Commune Or Nothing! Venezuela's Communal Movement and Its Socialist Project (2023). We agree that revitalizing the commune ought to be at the heart of socialist reconstruction in the present century. It represents the most effective response to the existential challenge facing humanity: how to avoid planetary ruination and build truly democratic, sustainable, and egalitarian societies.*

## Red Current, Pink Tide: El Maizal Commune

CHRIS GILBERT

In 2018, gruesome images of people stoning cattle began to circulate through Venezuela's social networks. The videos came from the countryside and showed people, driven by hunger and destitute, desperately solving their predicament by killing cattle and butchering them in the fields. Venezuela's city dwellers were struck with horror, but they also understood the situation. The crisis and the sanctions were bearing down hard on everyone. The average Venezuelan had lost twenty pounds, clothes hung loose on most people, and medicines were in short supply. It was hardly surprising, then, that the country's poorest were not going to sit around and starve, but rather chose to take matters into their own hands. At least they would be less hungry for a few nights.

At about the same time, in the center-west of the country, a group of seasoned militants from El Maizal Commune began to take stock of the situation in the crisis-ridden country. They were determined to act neither in terms of individual solutions nor to remain passive in the face of the challenge. As their main asset, they ran a mid-sized communal farm inaugurated shortly after president Hugo Chávez sent out the call to form communes in 2009. The farm had once been in private hands, but the tables were now turned, and it currently served some eight thousand people from twenty consejos comunales. The commune's charismatic leader, Ángel Prado, had once worked as a security guard on the land when it was private property.

With so many mouths to feed, El Maizal Commune's leaders knew that they had to strike out in a new direction. "We evaluated the situation," Prado explains to our group visiting from Caracas, "and opted to go on the offensive." They were inspired by Cuban ingenuity and resistance in the face of its sixty-year blockade, especially the island's ability to maintain its population thriving despite sanctions and threats. "We thought, let's apply Fidel's formula. Let's go on the offensive. . . . If having a means of production—say a herd of cattle, a corn field, or some other productive project—could provide us with the economic resources needed to overcome the crisis, then we'll take it!"

The following year, the communards quickly moved to occupy a neighboring pig farm that had once been in the state's hands but had fallen into disuse. They also took over a nearby abandoned university campus. It was all done with careful preparation, mobilizing workers from both locations and working with the neighbors. The newly acquired land and facilities were put under El Maizal's scheme of social

property: sharing with the community, internal democracy, and leadership that is answerable to the people. The commune's new assets were immediately set working to produce meat, cheese, and farmed fish. That is how El Maizal grew and prospered during the worst of times in Venezuela, becoming a symbol of resistance and a socialist vanguard in a country where, for most people, the only task is to survive.

### A Region with Historical Injustices

It is the summer of 2021, and a group of us from Caracas are traveling to Simón Planas township, where El Maizal Commune is located. We are doing so in an effort to catch up with the communal projects that are developing in the country. These days, Venezuela's vast rural hinterland evokes a forgotten episode in a magical realist novel. Because of the crisis and the gas shortages, adults move around on children's bicycles that the government gave away as Christmas gifts a few years ago. The roadways are full of big human forms hunched over those tiny-wheeled contraptions. They pedal hastily and recall circus clowns. All of this may appear amusing to an outsider, but these people's aims are dead serious: to get to work, see the doctor, or carry out some other necessary errand.

The land here is green and, at this time of year, luxuriant. Nearby mountains collect water that drains into a large valley opening onto the threshold of Venezuela's giant plains region. Important aquifers lie beneath the soil. Just to the north are the mysterious lands of Yaracuy that were much valued by Indigenous people for their year-round fertility. The main highway here leads in forty minutes to Barquisimeto, Venezuela's musical center. However, the melodies of that city, which are strummed on small guitars, give way in this valley to the sounds of llanero music, played on harps and full of improvised social content. The lyrics speak of the harsh realities of campesino life and often rail against landlords and the rich.

Because of its fertility and proximity to Venezuela's highly populated central region, this land was long sought after and fought over. After violently expropriating the territory from Indigenous people, a rural oligarchy set up shop, immortalizing themselves in the town and township names. By contrast, ordinary people in Simón Planas led scratch existences as peons on the haciendas of the rich. Until the Bolivarian Revolution, they spent their barely visible lives huddled in villages on the margins of thriving cattle and corn businesses. The contrast was and is shocking. Even now, Simón Planas is home to one of the biggest, most lucrative private slaughterhouses in South America. Just next to it is a huge rum-making complex that exports luxury drinks to Europe.

### A Socialist Holdout

One of the clown-cyclists is pedaling his way into the commune. We follow in our van as he turns into the driveway. At the entrance of El Maizal is a large billboard announcing the commune. It reads "Commune or Nothing!" and shows Chávez and Nicolás Maduro on horseback, with the former out in front and the latter hustling to catch up. Soon we arrive to the main cluster of farm buildings. This is no hippie commune: a heavy machinery shed lies off to one side on the right; a noisy corn flour processing unit rises up not far from it; a big cattle-tending complex, with spaces for



feeding, washing, and veterinary work, stretches out to the left. All the buildings bear names from the heroic Latin American revolutionary tradition: Camilo Torres (Colombian priest turned guerrillero), Argimiro Gabaldón (Venezuelan revolutionary leader), and Camilo Cienfuegos (martyred Cuban rebel). Tractors are constantly refilling with fertilizer and heading out to the fields, which extend in all directions from the busy rural headquarters.

We are met by Windely Matos, a veteran comunard and Prado's right-hand man. With typical Venezuelan no-holds-barred humor, he is usually referred to here as the "Messiah," because of his ability to solve all kinds of problems. As we listen to him explain how things work in El Maizal, we begin to realize how much this commune is like a time machine. The words that once circulated in the Chavista movement's heyday—terms like solidarity, sovereignty, and even socialism—but have since become mostly rhetoric in the official discourse in the cities, are fully meaningful in this rural commune combining production with social experiment.

"El Maizal is living proof that Chávez wasn't mistaken in wagering on the commune," Matos tells us. As if to explain what we have before our eyes, he goes on: "El Maizal shows that the commune is the only way to really satisfy the needs of the pueblo and build socialism. . . . For us, Chávez's project is alive, and we will defend and honor it with our lives." Here, among farm machinery, noisome chemicals, and the loud drone of grain-processing machines, his words are credible because they connect with a transformed reality. Far away from well-dressed and overfed bureaucrats, this comunard's hopefulness also recalls the spirited attitude of the early Chavista mobilizations.

Matos is keenly aware of the practical problem-solving required to keep a real movement alive. This is his strong suit. The U.S. sanctions are one of the main obstacles to the commune's progress (to say nothing of the well-being of the rest of Venezuelans). Cruel and pointless measures that restrict commerce in everything from fuel to medicine, these sanctions have struck hard against both rural and urban life in Venezuela. One of the commune's survival strategies has been to diversify its economy by incorporating the area's small producers into its network. The commune gives them credits and material support. They, in turn, cultivate what Matos calls "war crops": native beans, yuca, and sorghum. The small producers will later repay the commune with a part of their harvest.

Another huge problem is the local bourgeoisie who harass the commune, while regional bureaucrats too often side with them. The Messiah, however, is unfazed by the opposition put up by regional authorities. "It's well known that here, in this territory, there are two poles of Chavismo. There is a Chavista tendency in the local government that throws up all kinds of obstacles to communal development. Actually, it is not just obstacles," he acknowledges, "sometimes it's plain sabotage." Matos takes heart because he believes that Chávez foresaw such resistance to his plans. Moreover, he tells us how El Maizal has hatched a new strategy in their ongoing battle against the reformist bureaucracy. They will send their main spokesperson, Ángel Prado, to compete for the position of mayor in the upcoming regional elections. Musing

about this scenario, I can't suppress the thought that the "Messiah" in this commune—inverting biblical tradition—is announcing the plans of the Angel.

### True Believers

A few years ago, a revealing tragicomedy took place in Venezuela's plains region. The drama began when a handful of campesinos in the state of Barinas responded enthusiastically to Chávez's call to make communes. These were the truest of Chavista true believers. They set up their own commune and called it Eje Socialista (Socialist Axis). Ingenuous to the core, the Eje Socialista comunards decided to completely disobey the state. For them, the commune was the new authority, and the only one. They believed this totally and stuck to it until the end. After all, Chávez, though dead, was on their side! These forthright comunards were bold and honest. Nevertheless, after a few clashes with state authorities, all of them wound up in prison.

The comunards at El Maizal are not as extreme as those of Eje Socialista, nor as ingenuous. Yet, their dance with state authorities involves some of the same moves. It is true that they make a cult out of Chávez—who is painted, sculpted, and inscribed all over their commune—but, like most cults, El Maizal's way of paying homage to the dead leader can be highly subversive. It is always heretical to communicate directly with the maximum authority, without any mediation of high priests. Moreover, for El Maizal's comunards, loyalty to the former president also implies that they do not have to obey anyone else! So, the commune carries out its interpretation of Chávez's legacy, and that can mean anything from disregarding private property to defying government officials.

We are assembled in a thatched-roof canopy, not far from El Maizal's stern-looking bronze bust of Chávez, who seems to keep vigil over our meeting. Comunard Jennifer Lamus is with us explaining her work as an organizer of corn and cattle production. She is a good example of this commune's radical independence in the name of authority. "For my part," Lamus states, "I always say that El Maizal got where it is because of the rebelliousness of the army of women and men who make this whole project possible." It is working people who are at the center of this communal farm. They make the decisions but do so with a mandate that is beyond question. "When Chávez said, 'Commune or Nothing!' that order was carried out here, and it became our horizon. And we always say that we are willing to give up our lives for it. . . . If there is an obstacle, then we'll overcome it. Nothing should stand in the way of Chávez's dream."

Now the meaning of the grim face on El Maizal's Chávez bust is becoming clearer to me (I am warming up to it!). These people are seriously unwilling to back down before capitalist roaders in the government or among their land-owning neighbors. Lamus points out how the government hindering access to basic farm inputs can impede the commune's development, as happened two years ago, when El Maizal was facing the prospect of having no corn crop that season because the state institution AgroPatria refused to sell them seeds. Desperate, Prado and others decided to get the seeds by hook or by crook and bought them on the black market. The police soon arrived to put him and a few of his fellows in jail. Even so, the commune was

undaunted. Had not Chávez himself spent a great deal of time behind bars? A flurry of phone calls later to sympathetic lawyers and Chavista politicians in Caracas and they were all set free.

To overcome problems such as this, El Maizal is trying to join forces with other communes around the country. With this in mind, they have recently taken the lead in launching the Communard Union, an association of communes on a national level, which works to link up and strengthen those organizations committed to communal socialism in the country (discussed in chapter 6). The participating communes are already exchanging work brigades and supplying products to each other outside of the capitalist market. Lamus explains: “We are convinced that Chávez’s idea does not have to be a dream. . . . The Communard Union shows that many more people are joining forces with the communal project. That is how we can advance with this marvelous idea.”

Despite their occasional clashes with the government, everyone at El Maizal has internalized a keen political sense that keeps them from romanticizing the commune’s autonomy or from thinking of the Venezuelan state in unidimensional terms. These are lessons learned from Chavismo’s trajectory over the past two decades. This experience showed that popular power—grassroots control over the political and economic dimensions of a community—can grow much more solidly if it exists in a dialectical relation with the state. State support for autonomous projects might be anything from material assistance to a legal framework that defends popular power. The upshot of twenty years of Chavista experimentation, registered in the minds of millions of Venezuelans, is that state institutions, when sympathetic, can allow popular power to flourish locally and even project itself nationally and internationally.

The communal movement’s complex way of relating to the state is part of Venezuela’s special history, which includes its key role in founding the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries. Over the last one hundred years, people here have internalized the idea that the country’s oil and mineral resources belong to them collectively and should be used for popular welfare and grassroots development. They reason: the economic muscle of the state might not always be in the service of the common people, but it should be! Perhaps a fitting picture of this dialectical relation, this push and pull between sometimes sympathetic state institutions and defiant grassroots independence, is the image of this young communard seated near the figure of Chávez. She is appealing to the bronze president’s authority but doing so to defy the state in the name of a higher power!

### A Time Capsule

Sometimes an idea can bounce around in history before it finds a place where it can really take root. Chavismo first emerged among Venezuela’s urban masses and then, as is well known, broke into state circles and even came to hegemonize the region’s geopolitics. Soon, however, Chavismo began to be rolled back. It had a hard time weathering the economic crisis of 2008 and the falling oil prices that came later. A carefully executed coup d’état in Honduras—hitting at what was clearly the weak link in the chain of emancipated countries—was one of the first imperialist victories

against Chavista internationalism. Bureaucratization, stagnation, the leader’s poor health, and finally his death came next. Problems with succession and infighting were almost inevitable.

To many, it looked like Chavismo might completely disappear along with its leader, or that it would be deformed unrecognizably by the sanctions. Yet, all that was on the surface, far from the invisible movements of history that are often the most important ones. A not so well-known (but crucially important) development was that this mostly urban revolutionary movement had also made deep inroads into the rural regions. There, ordinary people, who were somewhat removed from the vicissitudes of official politics and the global economy, had also heard Chávez’s discourse, and they hearkened especially to his call to organize themselves and build communes. That is to say, Chavismo had quietly taken root in places that were not so visible: in the interstices of Venezuelan society and particularly in rural redoubts.

The biography of Prado, El Maizal’s main spokesperson, reflects the tortuous urban-rural trajectory of Chavista ideology. When young, Prado had been a coffee farmer in the area. However, he sold his farm and went to the city, becoming involved in politics. Along with thousands of other Venezuelan youths, Prado traveled to Cuba as part of the Frente Francisco de Miranda and, after returning, militated in that Chavista youth organization. Still, this lasted only until his support for a Communist Party candidate in regional elections got him expelled. Cast outside of the political sphere, Prado went back to his hometown, but without land, he ended up having to work security on a local farm complex. This farm later became El Maizal Commune. When a local group started to make moves to occupy the land he was guarding, Prado told his boss not to count on him and joined their ranks.

Prado’s life has been marked by many such odd twists and turns, most of them very fortunate. In 2009, he was lucky enough to be in the audience of the historic television program *Aló Presidente Teórico* No. 1 when Chávez laid out the theoretical basis of the commune, explaining the role of social property (while joking that many had interpreted socialism as a mere verbal baptism).<sup>1</sup> From the crowd, Prado spoke up and told Chávez about the land they had just occupied in Simón Planas township and their plans to manage it collectively. That year, Chávez visited El Maizal twice, leaving a permanent mark on the community and seeming to presage its extraordinary future.

Now, Prado is seated in the commune’s tiny office telling us how Chávez’s thinking about productive relations developed along with the practical experience of the Venezuelan masses: “Chávez’s theory evolved over time. He began with the cooperatives, but then realized that cooperatives only maintained the logic of private property. So, Chávez began to seek a form based on social property, and that is how the commune came about.” Prado’s assertion that cooperatives repeat the logic of private property might sound surprising. But these are lessons the Chavista movement learned both through its own concrete experience and by studying Yugoslavia’s socialist history. As these past experiences show, a cooperatively run enterprise can

have many owners—even completely equal ones—but still not serve the whole society, as should be the aim of social property.

El Maizal takes these lessons to heart. To comply with the social property model, the commune is not only democratically run (it has an internal parliament that decides what it will produce and how), but it is also very careful about what happens with its surpluses. In explaining the difference between cooperative private property and social property, Prado offers us an example: “If El Maizal were simply a cooperative, the surplus would go back into the production units here or it would be distributed among the co-op’s members. But that is not the case. Instead, because El Maizal is a commune, we redistribute the surplus through various social channels, and it can even be used to promote production in other communes.”

Prado is always thinking about how to spread the communal model, since improving the whole society’s well-being is the movement’s strategic goal. He and his colleagues reach out to other communities to pursue this aim, offering them both moral and material support. Just now, Prado is bubbling with enthusiasm about a newly founded commune in one of the poorest neighborhoods nearby. That community is mostly made up of women and children living in mud-hut ranchos. Respiratory problems are common among the group, which has also been hit hard by COVID. When the women started the commune, their main project was to acquire a nebulización (asthma treatment) center for their neighborhood, which they did by putting posters of Chávez and Che Guevara on a small hut and insisting that the state provide the medical equipment. They christened their project *Negra Hipólita*, after Simón Bolívar’s wet nurse.

Prado is passionate about this new initiative. It seems to prove his point that ordinary people, by organizing, can advance their goals even in a context of crisis, sanctions, and widespread political backpedaling. He believes that one can expand the grassroots basis of socialism—democratic control of resources—despite many external threats and high levels of internal defeatism. “The commune is a struggle of the pueblo. And the pueblo doesn’t just produce, participate, and defend the project. We also aspire to have popular control and self-government in the whole territory.... The Chavista struggle for justice in these rural areas won’t stop.”

### **Conflict and Resistance**

Over the past two decades, the government’s agrarian policy has tended to swing between voluntarism and pragmatism. The mainstays of the Bolivarian Process may have been essentially urban and military, but the government still had to determine what its rural policy would be. The 2001 Land Law, which allowed for the occupation of unused land, was indeed very radical, and in fact became a precipitating factor for the 2002 coup d’état. Likewise, Chávez’s longstanding agricultural minister Elías Jaua and successor Juan Carlos Loyo were both generally left leaning, a high point in their tenures being the sweeping land expropriations of 2006–2009. Unfortunately, many of the ministry’s more radical projects at the time failed to connect with social movements in the rural areas, and ministry officials were willing to hypocritically inaugurate projects that barely existed.

In 2009 and 2010, Chávez began to promote the commune, which was clearly a revolutionary option for rural Venezuela. Yet, after Chávez died and Maduro took over, the fledgling agriculture minister Yván Gil adopted a more pragmatic approach, including pacts with the rural bourgeoisie, the so-called “producers.” When current agricultural minister Wilmar Castro Soteldo came on the scene a few years later, that pragmatism became outright class collaboration, with the rural bourgeoisie being declared “revolutionary.” In a surprising move, Castro Soteldo went on television and delivered long, eclectic discourses—even quoting Sor Juana Inés de la Cruz, the Mexican poet-nun—to explain how Venezuela’s bourgeoisie could be revolutionary. At least you could not blame the minister for playing his cards too close to his chest!

The communards at El Maizal oppose Castro Soteldo’s capitalist-roader tendency, which they call reformism. (Perhaps more than reformist, the minister should be called antipopular. As Prado says: “If you really want to change things, you have to give power over to the people,” which Castro Soteldo seems unwilling to do.) To combat this kind of institutional backsliding and leverage the government, El Maizal’s communards are employing a number of tactics in what they see as a battle to force President Maduro and his cabinet over to their side. Part of this struggle is a huge drive for political education of people in the region, to raise levels of ideological formation. Another part of their plan is the Commune Union: reaching out to other communes and preaching by the example of solidarity. Finally, and much more controversially, they have a newly hatched project to make Prado into the local mayor. By obtaining the post, the commune’s main spokesperson is supposed to achieve practical solutions for the community (solving their garbage disposal and seed problems, for example) and also speak up for socialism inside the government apparatus.

Some of the commune’s most trusted sympathizers are skeptical about this latest move. Will an official position distract Prado from grassroots work? Could holding power in the township’s government corrupt El Maizal’s leaders? Whatever one’s doubts about this new effort—and I share them—it is impressive to see the campaign the commune is carrying out in the week of our visit. Elections involving massive mobilization are a Venezuelan specialty. It is a terrain they navigate with great skill—evidence of the unique Chavista experience of repurposing elections for revolutionary ends. During the course of the summer, the tasks of going house to house, and of rallying people with enthusiasm and “mystique” have consumed many of the commune’s militants. The social networks that El Maizal employs have also become torrents of information related to the campaign, along with images of marches, neighborhood cookouts, and other gatherings.<sup>2</sup>

Inadvertently, I make a contribution to Prado’s campaign imagery. It happens because I was invited to join El Maizal’s WhatsApp group and many of the group’s users reached out to me with hearty welcomes. Not knowing how to respond, being out of my element in social networks, I sent a smiley face and then hunted down the red flag emoticon to accompany it. The little red flag turned out to be a huge hit in the midst of the election campaign. El Maizal’s communards began to tag most of the

photos of marches, rallies, and meetings related to the campaign with one or more waving flags (often coupled with flexed biceps and raised fists).

Why was the red flag icon so popular at El Maizal? It might be because Chávez had used “socialist red” in his campaigns, whereas the current government’s commitment to that project (and color!) seems to be more precarious. Alternatively, it could be simply that socialist references reach deeply into Venezuela’s history, having been lodged there by the communist-affiliated movements that rose up and dominated the country’s left from the 1960s through the 1980s. Whichever of these motives is most relevant, I am delighted by the headway made by the red flag in this commune because it points to the persistence of very “red” elements in the so-called Pink Tide. However, it also raises the question of the role of the past and historical memory in shaping the communes, which is the subject of our next chapter.

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## Socialism’s Self-Criticism and Real Democracy

RICHARD D. WOLFF

Democracy is incompatible with class-divided economic systems. Masters rule in slavery, lords in feudalism, and employers in capitalism. Whatever forms of government (including representative-electoral) coexist with class-divided economic systems, the hard reality is that one class rules the other. The revolutionaries who overthrew other systems to establish capitalism sometimes meant and intended to install a real democracy, but that did not happen. Real democracy—one person, one vote, full participation, and majority rule—would have enabled larger employee classes to rule smaller capitalist classes. Instead, capitalist employers used their economic positions (hiring/firing employees, selling outputs, receiving/distributing profits) to preclude real democracy. What democracy did survive was merely formal. In place of real democracy, capitalists used their wealth and power to secure capitalist class rule. They did that first and foremost inside capitalist enterprises where employers functioned as autocrats unaccountable to the mass of their employees. From that base, employers as a class purchased or otherwise dominated politics via electoral or other systems.

Socialism as a critical movement, before and after the 1917 revolution in Russia, targeted the absence of real democracy in capitalism. Socialism’s remarkable global spread over the last three centuries attests to the wisdom of having stressed that target. Capitalism’s employee class came to harbor deep resentment toward its employer class. Shifting circumstances determined how conscious that resentment became, how explicit its expressions, and how varied its forms.

A certain irony of history made the absence of real democracy in socialist countries an ongoing target of many socialists in those countries. More than a few socialists commented on the shared problem of that absence in both capitalist and socialist countries notwithstanding other differences between them. The question thus arose: why would the otherwise different capitalist and socialist systems of the late 20th and early 21st centuries display quite similar formal democracies (apparatuses of voting) and equally similar absences of real democracy? Socialists developed answers that entailed a significant socialist self-criticism.

Those answers and self-criticism flowed from a recognition that in both capitalist and socialist systems, business enterprises (factories, offices, stores) were organized overwhelmingly around the dichotomy of employer and employee. This was and remains true of private enterprises, whether more or less state-regulated, and likewise of state-owned-and-operated business enterprises. In parallel fashion, much the same was true in slave economic systems: the master-slave organization of productive activities prevailed in both private and state enterprises. Similarly, the lord-serf organization of production prevailed in both state (royal) and private (vassal) feudal enterprises.

Real democracy proved equally incompatible with slave, feudal, capitalist, and socialist systems in so far as the socialist systems retained the prevailing employer-employee structure of their enterprises. In fact, the three kinds of modern socialist systems all display that employer-employee structure. Western European social democracies do so because they leave most production in the hands of private capitalist enterprises that were always built on employer-employee foundations. Moreover, when they established and operated public or state-owned-and-operated enterprises, they copied those employer-employee structures.

Soviet industries—chiefly publicly owned and operated—positioned state officials as employers in relation to employees. Finally, the People's Republic of China comprises a hybrid form of socialism combining a mix of both of the other forms, a roughly equal split of private and state enterprises. China's hybrid socialism shares the employer/employee organizational structure in both its state and private enterprises. All three kinds of socialism—social democratic, Soviet, and Chinese—broke in many important ways from the capitalism that preceded them. But they did not break from the basic employer-employee organization of enterprises, that relationship which Marx's *Capital* pinpoints as the source of exploitation, that appropriation by employers of the surplus produced by employees.

All three kinds of modern socialism remain crucially incomplete in terms of having not yet gone beyond the employer-employee organization of production. It follows that socialists' self-criticism—that actually-existing socialist systems fell short of their standard of real democracy—may be linked crucially to those systems' retention of the employer-employee relationship at their economic core.

Employers and employees are, together, defined by a specific class structure. They are its poles; the two possible positions individuals hold in production. They emerged with capitalism out of the disintegrations of previous systems. Such prior systems included (1) feudalism and its economic structure's two positions of lord and serf, and (2) slavery and its economic structure's two positions of master and slave. Because masters, lords, and employers are usually few relative to the numbers of slaves, serfs, and employees, and because they live off the surplus extracted from those slaves, serfs, and employees, they cannot allow a real democracy as it would directly threaten their class positions and privileges. In actually-existing socialist societies, real democracy's incompatibility with class-divided economic systems is encountered yet again.

Because this time it is many socialists who make the encounter, they ask why modern socialism, a social movement critical of capitalism's lack of real democracy, would itself merit a parallel criticism. Why have socialist experiments to date produced a self-criticism focused on their inability to create and maintain authentic democratic systems??

The answer lies in the employer-employee relationship. It always was the key obstacle to real democracy, the cause and literally the definition of those classes whose oppositional existence precludes real democracy. Those socialists who faced the problem of real democracy articulated it as a definition of/demand for "classlessness." Without classes, no ruling class. If the employees become, collectively, their

own employer, the capitalist class opposition disappears. One group or community replaces two. Absent a class-divided economic system, efforts to bring real democracy to a society's economy and politics could anticipate success.

Socialist self-criticism can enable a solution to real democracy's absence by advocating for a transition from an employer/employee-based economic system to one based on workers' self-directed enterprises (or "worker coops" in common language). The incomplete socialisms constructed in the 20th century need to be upgraded by making that transition. That would get those socialisms nearer to completion, nearer to real democracy, and further from capitalist systems whose undying commitment to the employer-employee relationship precludes them from ever getting closer to real democracy.

*This article was produced on 7 Dec., 2023, by [Economy for All](#), a project of the Independent Media Institute.*

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Carol Simpson CartoonWork



# Dis-honest Broker

RAYMOND NAT TURNER

(for my friend Farid)

Metallic music of shovels; Abrasions on bare hands  
Digging, digging, digging through twisted bones and  
busted bricks of buildings. To backpacks, blankets, baby  
body parts to free tiny arms and legs emitting whispers...

Obese bulldozers munching homes and olive trees;  
Settlers snacking on bones of the evicted;  
Aquifer flooded with sea water and sewage are G-  
Rated nightmares and matter not to NFL, NBA bi-partisans

Forked tongue, dis-honest broker, fluent in ancient language  
Genocide  
Trots tattered tropes for terror out. Swears another Offal Office  
Oath on War House Bible—bathed in blood of 10s of millions: Wounded Knee  
to Trail of Tears; Tulsa to Hiroshima; Korea to  
Vietnam to Afghanistan...

Riddler/Joker—Dis-  
honest broker: “You have a right to”  
Be an aircraft carrier on the desert  
Acting as a weapons lab conducting  
Trade shows; Disguised as democracy  
Acting as an apartheid state; Concealing  
Third Reich real estate practices—Go on  
Step on the gas—and  
“Mow the grass!”

“You have a right to” quell them/Shell  
them! Bombard them/boneyard them!  
Snipe them/wipe them! Un-home them/Pogrom them!  
Expel them/Farewell them!

“You have a right to” strangulate them/Annihilate them!  
Bomb roads they’re instructed to travel—Let them eat  
Lead and gravel!

“You have a right to” kill them One-a-Day... for years—Daily... for decades...  
Until bloody bootprints become  
Normal as “Ironclad!” Normal as Baghdad...  
“You have a right to” 22 days of carnage; provided  
you Madison Avenue it: “Operation Caste-Lead!”  
“You have a right to” Step on the gas—and  
“Mow the grass!”

“You have a right to” 51 days of slaughter—if  
you market it as: “Operation Protective Edge!”  
“You have a right to” Step on the gas—and  
“Mow the grass!”

“You have a right to” Dr. Goebbels’ white phosphorus  
prescriptions for human animals holding human shields;  
Holding hostages; Holding hospital hideouts; Holding  
House keys—for... 3/4 of a Century...

*Former forklift driver/warehouse worker/janitor, Raymond Nat Turner is a NYC  
poet; BAR’s Poet-in-Residence; and founder/co-leader of the jazz-poetry ensemble  
UpSurge!NYC. [Read other articles by Raymond Nat](#), or [visit Raymond Nat’s website](#).*

## Professor's Response to Columbia Deans

RASHID KHALIDI

Our deans state that the Columbia community should acknowledge “that hearing chanted phrases such as ‘by any means necessary,’ ‘from the river to the sea,’ or calls for an ‘intifada’—irrespective of intentions and provenance—is experienced by many Jewish, Israeli, and other members of our community as antisemitic and deeply hurtful.”

They have thus unilaterally decided that no one should rise up [the actual meaning of “intifada”] against 56 years of illegal military occupation; that Palestine should remain unfree from the river to the sea; and that the oppressed should take permission from the oppressor as to the means to relieve their oppression. They have come to this decision because hearing otherwise is “antisemitic and deeply hurtful” to some. In determining what speech is permissible and what is not, they have in effect banned the political, while acknowledging the humanitarian, such that expressing “anguish about the loss of Palestinian lives” does not make one antisemitic or a supporter of terrorism (which mouthing other words presumably does). There is no equivalence whatsoever between these two acknowledgments.

This statement amounts to a new norm that prohibits using or learning about these terms and their histories, in favor of the privileging of a politics of feeling. While perhaps appropriate to a kindergarten, it is hard to imagine an approach more contrary to the most basic idea of a university.

This statement is characteristic of a university that picks a task force nearly devoid of expertise on antisemitism and on Palestine/Israel (much of which exists among the faculty), but packed with outspoken advocates for Israel, a university that has decided that faculty expertise on freedom of speech or on language to be proscribed should be rigorously excluded from deliberations on such issues. With complete disregard for the principle of faculty governance, crucial matters like these are being decided upon by administrators, presumably with hefty input from trustees, donors and politicians, who have negligible expertise, but robust and one-sided opinions.

This is the latest instance of Columbia's discrimination against Palestinian, Arab, Muslim, and other students who support Palestinian rights, ignoring the grave material consequences they face within the university, and from a hostile political, media and corporate environment, for protesting an assault that has so far killed over 20,000 and wounded 50,000, the heaviest such toll in Palestinian history. Such a statement would have no place in a self-respecting university that cherishes and protects academic freedom and freedom of speech in the face of pressures from powerful outside interests.

*Rashid Ismail Khalidi is a Palestinian-American historian of the Middle East and the Edward Said Professor of Modern Arab Studies at Columbia University. His latest book is Hundred Years' War on Palestine (2021).*

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*Henry Kissinger died on November 29 at age 100 without facing trial for all the blood on his hands. That is an indictment of a political system that cannot deliver a minimum of justice for perpetrators of mass murder. We might say that a requirement for high office in an empire as opposed to a genuine republic is precisely the willingness to commit war crimes and crimes against humanity. This willing warmonger's actions and decisions led to the deaths of over 3 million people across the globe. Here is what the US Department of State said on his death: “A statesman in every sense of the word, he felt a duty and desire to serve America.” Those who know a thing or two about this vile man and the machinations of the US Empire know that he did not ‘serve America’ but the US Empire.*

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*US imperialism's addiction to war continues apace.* The latest example is the full support and backing of the genocidal assault waged by Israel on the people of Gaza by the US, ostensibly in response to the 7 October attack on Israel by Hamas fighters. Several articles in this issue of Left Turn deal with this subject. However, here we would like to include a local item about the ongoing genocide in Gaza: The people of Easton, PA send \$367,656 annually of their taxes to the Israeli military to maintain a brutal settler colonial apartheid regime. But the Easton City Council removed a Resolution introduced by Councilmember Taiba Sultana that called for a ceasefire in Gaza even though most Americans favor it. The mayor of Easton, Salvatore J. Panto Jr., also refused to back the resolution. People in every city in the US should know exactly how much they are contributing to the Israeli military forces from their taxes and pressure their city councils to pass resolutions demanding a truce in Gaza. Our taxes and our silence make us all complicit in the ongoing genocide in Gaza.

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*The dehumanization of the Palestinians* is so prevalent that the maiming and killing of by now over 11,000 innocent Palestinian infants and children in Gaza evokes no visible or public compassion, empathy, or condemnation from the political class even though there are thousands of videos out there reaching millions of people. There is so much cultural work that needs to be done in combating Islamophobia before we can hope to have a world in which the US policymakers find it difficult to kill Arab others with impunity and without any remorse. You could say given unchallenged Islamophobic framings, the public kills the Arabs in its minds first before the politicians kill them in real life. If one ever needed proof of the power of ideas that frame the way we see the world, one need not look further than how our society is reacting to the barrage of harrowing daily images of the deaths of hundreds of the most vulnerable in Palestine with the full complicity of our political class. The one silver lining in all this is the shift in the attitudes of the 18–29-year-old age group who are now more sympathetic to the Palestinians than to Israel. Perhaps the future will be brighter than meets the eye.

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*Fake Imperial Feminism:* A tweet by Jake Sullivan, the National Security Advisor to Biden: “The United States will continue to press for the rights of women and girls, and work with the international community to hold Iran accountable for the violations

of the Iranian people's human rights." Note that Mr. Sullivan is arguably the chief enabler of Israel in the Biden administration in the ongoing killings of more than 11,000 innocent Palestinian women and infants in Gaza in the past 80 days. He does not care about the violations of women's rights. That should be clear. He cares not for the deaths of thousands in Gaza, killed with his direct support in one place but feigns concern for the rights of the living women in another. He is not revealing the hidden agenda behind his statement.



Suzy Adnan Tamimi

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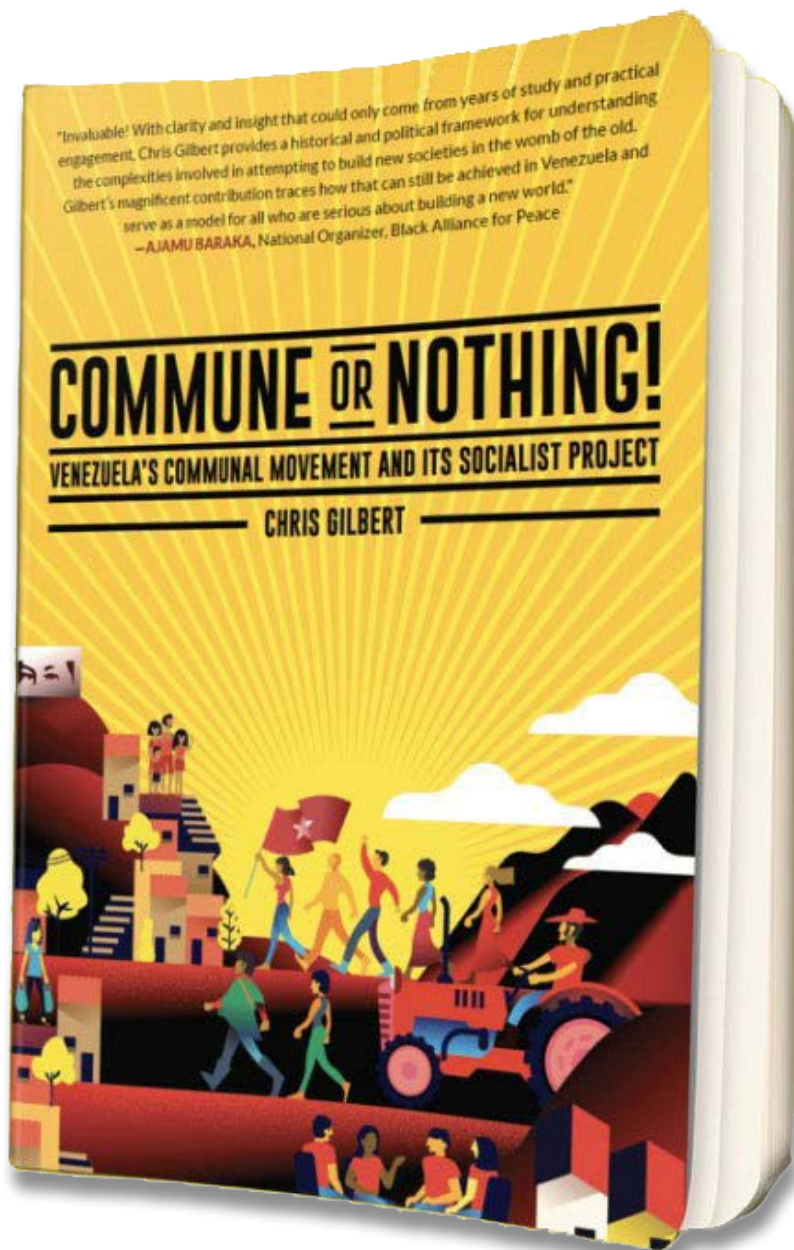


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*The cover of Chris Gilbert's new book was a collaboration with the Venezuelan collective Utopix.cc. (Monthly Review Press, 2023)*

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